Fake Dating 101

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Huntara (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra)

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by lologoblens

Summary

In a moment of complete and utter idiocy, Catra blurted out the existence of a new girlfriend in her life. To her ex-girlfriend and coworker. With their company's holiday party just two weeks away, Catra needs a plan and she needs one fast.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

"I did something bad." Catra drops in front of Bow at high table in their usual bar, her tail flicking irritably behind her. It's happy hour and Catra plans to make the most of that tonight. Blessedly her friend has already ordered her first drink. She downs the martini in one go and Bow looks on with wide eyes. Whatever, not like she has a human's tolerance.

"Uh oh what did you do?" Catra stares at him, eyes hard. Then she blinks and pretends to survey the bar.

"I may need to borrow Glimmer for date."

"*What?*"

"To my work holiday party."

"*Catra…*"

"It's next Friday."

"I'm sorry, what exactly is going on here?"

Catra huffs and flags down a waiter to order another round. As he walks away, she admits, "I maybe told Mermista that I have a new girlfriend."

"Oh, Wildcat." He begins pityingly.

"Whatever, can I borrow your girlfriend or not?"

"Okay, well first of all, I don't own her. You'd have to ask her yourself."

"I'm just making sure you're not gonna get all butt hurt about it!" She protests, tail thrashing more wildly. He ignores her.

"Second, you seem to be forgetting that Glimmer's parent's firm does a lot of work with Dryl Tech"…

"Fuck," Catra deflates, ears drooping. "You guys are already going, aren't you?"

He grimaces. "Yeah."

"*Fuck*."

"Why Glimmer anyway?" Bow pushes, smiling at their returning waiter in thanks. "Don't you have any single friends you can ask?"

She rolls her eyes as hard as she can manage. "Bow, come on."

"What?"

"You don't ask an available friend!"

"Why not?" He looks confused and she downs another drink, her left ear flicking.

"It's fake dating 101, dude! You can't risk falling in love with them."

He actually laughs right in her face. She tries to flag their waiter down again, but it goes unnoticed. Why do they even keep coming to this bar? It's way too *uppity*. Close to her and Bow's respective offices though, so that's probably it. "I'm sorry, aren't you still hung up on Mermista? Why are you worried about falling for one of your friends?"

"I'm not *hung up on Mermista!*" She hisses. "We're friends, it's chill. I've moved on, Bow!"

"Uh huh." He gives her a look painted with doubt. "So why did you feel the need to lie about a fake girlfriend then?"

"*Ugh,* so fucking stupid." She groans, finally catching their waiter's attention. She just holds up her glass, no need for him to come over all this way. "She was just going on and on about Sea Hawk, and how she couldn't believe how much her parents *actually like him*."

She steals Bow's untouched second round for a large gulp. "Which, I'm sure you'll remember how Mr. Sealineas felt about *me*."

"Ouch." He winces.

"I mean, it's not like I *care*; it's been a year and I'm fucking over it. We were never gonna work out long term anyway. It's just, then she asked if I was bringing a plus one." Another gulp to polish off Bow's drink as their waiter sets down her third, technically fourth, round. "Blech, and she had that *stupid*, smirky Mermista face on… what was I supposed to *say*?"

Bow furrows his brow and watches her sip at her fourth drink with mild concern. She ignores it, though the fur on her arms raises despite herself. "Uh, that you were bringing a friend?"

"Shut up." Is about all she can come up with for that.

"Well, what are you gonna do? You could ask Scorpia."

"*What?* No way! We had that weird romantic tension senior year of college, that's just asking for trouble!"

He laughs again, waiving the waiter down to get an actual second round for himself. Catra's gonna have to tip well tonight with all the running around this poor schmuck is doing for them. "That was like, five years ago!"

"Bow, it's a fucking rom com waiting to happen. Plus, she's with that new chick, fuck, what's her name?"

"Perfuma." Bow supplies. She taps her nose and points at him.

"Yes, her. Seems like the jealous type to me. Besides, Mermista already knows her so she'd know right away she was lying." Bow gives her a look that clearly communicates his skepticism. "It's a no, Crop Top."

"I'm in a suit!" He gestures at himself.

She eyes him up shrewdly. "Yeah, and it looks weird. Shoulda gotten a job as a camp counselor or something. You look weird in shirts."

He guffaws at the comment. "Gee, thanks."

She shrugs, it's just true. "Who else do we even fucking know?" She returns to her dilemma. "Do we know any straight girls? A straight girl would be *perfect* for this. Literally no risk."

Bow makes a face and thinks for a second. "Uh. Angella."

"Fuck you." She laughs, finishing her fourth drink. "First of all, if I can't take Glimmer, her *mom* is definitely not gonna work. Second, there's no *way* that woman is straight."

Bow bobs his head side to side in a gesture that says, '*fair enough*'. "Okay, yeah, I literally cannot think of a single straight woman right now."

"Yeah, me neither." They settle into thought and their waiter drops another drink by Catra, clearing her empty glass. And yeah, that's gonna be a big fucking tip. Her tail begins to sway more languidly as the alcohol starts to hit her.

"Oh! What about Adora?"

Catra scrunches her face. "Adora? Oh, shit! Glimmer's roommate, Adora?" Bow nods. "Wait, is she not straight?"

Bow tips his head to the side and makes a face at her. "Catra, have you ever *seen* a lesbian before?" She gives him a droll look and he shakes his head. "Whatever, no she's *definitely* not straight."

"Weird, okay. Guess I haven't spent that much time around her." She thinks about this. Adora's cool, they see each other at group events sometimes and she's always chill. Kinda reminds Catra of a golden retriever; sorta sweet, sorta dopey, but clearly very smart. It's a

dangerous combo, definite rom com fodder…then again, what choice has she got?

"So." Bow prompts.

She huffs and notices the room start to spin just a little. "I mean, I literally can't think of anyone else."…

He narrows his eyes at her. "Just how serious about this are you?"

"Meh." She shakes a hand noncommittally. "I dunno."

His eyebrows raise. "Well, best of luck to you, I guess. Listen, you were super late," She scoffs. "so, I actually need to get going. You need a ride?" He's clearly not asking. To be fair she did have…what was it? Five drinks? Six? She's not drunk, but she's definitely not sober either. She throws on her jacket and follows him to his car.

The ride home is quiet, in her inebriation Catra has fallen into a contemplative state. Her friend lets her sit and stew, playing with the end of her tail. She forgets how *soft* it is until she's buzzed.

Bow drops her off at her apartment, driving off after he's sure she's in safely. Once inside Catra lures her cat out and snuggles Melog to her chest until they manage to squirm out of her arms. Then she pulls off her tie and jacket and flops onto her couch. How does she even get into these situations?

She thinks about pulling out her phone, biting the bullet and texting Adora. She's too tipsy though. Instead, she flicks on the TV and falls asleep to a shitty documentary about birds or some shit. In the morning she does *not* thank her drunk self for the decision to sleep on the couch. Her back is a wreck.

Melog wakes her up by walking across her face. She growls at them, but they just start purring and kneading her chest. She rolls her eyes fondly and shoves them off, getting up to feed them to make up for it.

Next order of business is food. She stares in her fridge for about fifteen minutes before deciding on toast. Just plain ass toast.

Sitting at her kitchen counter, munching at her lackluster breakfast, her mind drifts back to her conundrum. She pulls up Adora's contact in her phone, then opens their messages. There's very few between them, just one exchange actually . Adora's address from the time she threw Glimmer a surprise party a year ago, and clarification on timing. That's probably a bad sign, they're barely even friends.

Then again, that means there' s only so much to lose.

Catra

Hey Adora! So I know this might be really weird but-

She deletes everything, her ears pining back.

Catra

Hey Adora, want free dinner?

That's *clearly* a no go.

Catra

Hey Adora, I need a favor. See there's this holiday party at my work and-

Way too much info. It takes her a few more drafts to get it right. And a half a pot of freshly brewed coffee. She glares at the bitter drink, Catra barely even *likes* coffee. Whatever, she groans and decides to keep it simple.

Catra

Hey Adora.

The minute 'sending' changes to 'sent' under her message she slams her phone down on the counter. Feels like as good a time as any to start her laundry. She's only been putting it off for two weeks now…

It doesnt take nearly long enough. Maybe she should start separating out her loads, instead of chucking everything in together. A problem for another day she supposes.

She eyes her phone from across the room. She's pretty sure her fridge needed clearing out when she looked in there this morning. That takes a solid half hour. She's gotta start eating her leftovers. Catra stands in the middle of her kitchen, hands on her hips, and looks at her phone warily. As if it's gonna come to life and launch an attack.

She should get dressed, it's already eleven. She throws on jeans and a cozy sweater and walks back into the living room. She looks at her phone again and as she does her stomach rumbles. The only thing she wants to do *less* than check for this message is cook for herself. She picks up the stupid fucking phone. Adora's already messaged her back.

Adora

Hey Catra!

How have you been?

Catra growls and closes out of the message, tail thrashing wildly behind her. What the fuck is she supposed to say to that!It' s time for food and she's not about to make it herself. She throws on shoes and a coat, grabs her keys and walks to her door. Andher car is still at the bar. She could call a ride, but she's barely fit to interact with her *cat* whose been hiding under the bed all morning. Let alone another person. She drops onto the couch.

Catra

Um, pretty good. You?

Adora

Good!

Just same old, same old, ya know?

Of course, she replies instantly.

Adora

What's up?

"*Fuck*."It' s now or never.

Catra

Well…

I sort of have a favor to ask

Sorry!I know we dont know each other THA T well…

Adora

No worries!

We know each other plenty :)

Is this about the work party thing?

"*Stars fucking damn you, Bow Archer!*"Hell be getting a piece of her mind very, very soon.

Catra

Haha, yeah

Bow told you?

Adora

He did!

I think he thought you were joking.

Or umdrunk lol

Catra

Wow, okay, this is embarrassing

Forget I said anything

Sorry to bug you on a Saturday!

Adora

Wait!

Catra stops just shy of throwing her phone across the room at the immediate reply.

Adora

What's the situation exactly?

Catra can feel herself turn red. She really shouldn't entertain this, but if Adora's offering…

Catra

I sort of lied

About having a girlfriend

You know, like a dumbass

Adora

Why?

Catra

I sort of work with my ex-girlfriend?

Adora

Is that a question?

Catra

Shut up!

Then immediately she corrects herself.

Fuck, sorry

I'm asking you for a favor

Her tail wraps around her left leg and she rests her face in her hand.

Adora

Lol, ur fine!

Soare we trying to make her jealous?

Catra's heart skips at the use of the word 'we'. She sinks further into her couch.

Catra

No!

No, it's not like that

It's a long story but I'm over her

I just was being stupid

And I dont want her and my other coworkers who heard to know that lol

Adora

Gotcha!

Okay, when is it?

Catra

Two weeks from tonight

Adora

Cool!I can probably get that night of f!

Catra

Off?Where do you work?

Adora

Raż s Diner?

Catra

Oh shit!I love that place

Adora

Haha, yeah, food’s good

Iḿ front of house tho

Catra

So…

Are you actually considering this?

Adora

The party?

Catra

Yeah

There’s a fancy dinner

Admittedly therell probably be speeches…

But also, open bar!

Adora

Cool, yeah I can be there!

Isten

Catra’s heart skips again

Adora

I work in a couple hours

We should probably get our story straight and stuff

Would you wanna meet me at the diner in an hour?

We can have lunch and talk about it?

That gives Catra plenty of time to pick up her car. She supposes too that she does need to eat…

Catra

Sounds good

Seriously I cannot thank you enough.

Adora

No problem!

Catra sighs with relief even as nerves make her hands shake and her tail puff up. She's really doing this. It's gonna be fine. totally and completely fine.

⁂

"Glimmer , *relax*, it's gonna be fine!" Adora assures as she digs around her dresser for her name tag.

Glimmer huffs from her spot on Adora's bed. "You're gonna catch feelings. Come on, Adora! This is fake dating AU 101!"

Adora laughs and turns around to face her. "Sorry , what?"

Her roommate rolls her eyes. "Uh, it' s like a rom com writing itself before my very eyes. The sassy protagonist needs a date to make her ex jealous-"

"She said she' s not trying to make her jealous." Adora clarifies.

Glimmer ignores her. "Then in walks the wide eyed, gentle potential love interest."

"Wide eyed and gentle?" Adora giggles, resuming her search. "You make me sounds like Bambi."

"Not that much of a stretch, Adora. Stop interrupting!" She hardly agrees with that assessment, but Adora shuts up and lets her friend continue her tirade. It's coming either way. "As I was saying. In walks the potential love interest, all sweet and naïve. They both think the night is gonna be totally innocent."

"It' s not I take it?" Adora smirks, giving up on the name tag and pulling on her khakis.

"*Shut up*, Adora! Gosh! So, they're naïve idiots because *of course* they have a fabulous night. Sparks fly, the protagonist totally forgets about their loser ex."

"I think they're on good terms, Glim. Isn't that what Bow said? I probably wouldn't get involved if I thought it was gonna be like… *drama*."

"Listen, do you want to know how the movie ends, or not?"

Her lips purse. "The movie that is your interpretation of how my future's gonna look?"

Glimmer's jaw sets. "Yes."

"Sure, why not? I have to leave in ten though, so."

"Right, so you have this amazing, magical evening. Both of you feel the romance but you think it's fake, so you ignore it. She drops you off, you linger on the doorstep. You both start to lean in *and then…* someone panics and the night ends. Feelings are hurt, you both feel insecure and are too afraid to call."

"Okay, I've never been afraid to call a girl before." It's a little cocky, but also true. Adora's confident, so sue her.

"Famous last words." She's warned in a dangerous tone. She merely scoffs. "So, you're now both pining and then finally, *finally* the protagonist breaks and calls-"

"Okay, I'm just gonna stop you right here."

"Hey! I'm almost to the climax."

"Seriously?" Adora feels her eyebrow lift.

"Oh, knock it off! Don't make it dirty."

"Whatever . Im just saying, this sounds like a warning but at the end of rom coms arent both people likehappy?"

Glimmer shrugs. "Im not sure I think Catra' s right for you."

Adora frowns at the assessment. "Why not? She' s always seemed chill."

"*Chill?*" Glimmer question incredulously . "Catra Bluth, *Catarina* Bluth, chill?"

She makes a face and shrugs back. "Uhyeah."

"Literally the last word I would use to describe that woman, but okay . She's soprickly ."

Adora laughs and pulls on a long sleeved shirt. "Glimmer , *you're* prickly."

That earns her a pout. "W ell yeah, but Im cute too!"

Another shrug. "Catra' s pretty cute."

At this Glimmer stands from the bed. She sticks a finger in Adora's face and, even with a height disadvantage of ten inches, she manages to somehow tower over her. "See! This, this right here! Y ou *said* you werent gonna fall in love with her . And just look at you!"

Adora laughs so hard she snorts, and she grabs her wallet and keys. "Im not gonna *fall in love with her*, Glimmy. She's a pretty lady and Id be blind to not see that. Doesnt mean there' s chemistry. Besides, well set boundaries and itll be one evening. No big deal."

"Adora..." Glimmer continues to protest. Adora pats the top of her head and grabs her jacket off the end of the bed.

"I have to go; Ill see you tonight? Or are you at Bow' s?"

Glimmer harrumphs. "Yeah, I'm at Bow's. But we are so talking about this on Sunday!"

"You bet, bye Glim!" Without another word she zips out of their apartment and out to her truck. She lives pretty close to the diner, close enough to walk on a good day. When it's dropping below forty though it's good to have the car.

She walks in and spots Catra immediately, as the only magicat in the diner, she's pretty hard to miss. Not that it's all that busy. She doesn't notice Adora until she's right up on her and clears her throat. Catra jumps with an *adorable* little squeak and immediately blushes. Adora can't help her wide smile. "Hey!"

"Hey Adora. Um, thanks. For doing this. I feel a little silly to be honest."

She shrugs out of her jacket and takes the seat across from her. "Don't even worry about it, we've all been there. Lesbian solidarity, right?"

Catra laughs and it's so out of character. Not the laughing, but the sound. Catra's voice is all low and raspy, sensual one might even say. Her laugh though it's high and squeaky, almost childlike. It's the cutest damn thing in the world, honestly. That and her six freckles. Literally exactly six. "Yeah, okay dork."

Mara catches Adora's eye and she sends a signal for coffee. She gets a thumbs up and she turns back to Catra with a shrug. "So, two weeks you said?"

Catra nods. "Yeah, it's just gonna be a dumb office party, but it's swanky."

"Okay, so no jeans then?"

A snort. "Yeah, please no. A dress or a suit or whatever is good."

"Cool, I can do that. So, what' s our story?"

"Our story?" Catra questions.

"Y eah, like how did we meet and get together, how long has it been, that kind of stuff."

"Oh, fuck I didnt even think of that." Catra admits with a grimace.

"All good! How long ago did you and um…"

"Mermista." She supplies.

"Right, how long since you broke up?"

"Eh, little over a year ."

"Cool, how long did you date?"

Catra eyes her. "Why does that matter?"

Adora cant hold back an eye roll. "W ell, we should gauge how long you'd need to get over her , right? Otherwise, I'm just a rebound. Like if you dated for a month, a few weeks is fine. If you-"

"T wo years."

Adora blinks. "Oh, so y'all were like… *serious* then."

"Pft, hardly ." Adora tips her head in askance. "W e were like glorified friends with benefits. Merms is great but not exactly one for commitment, and that's not really what I was looking for either."

"Got it. Okay , so is our relationship casual then?"

Catra blushes and turns away. As she does Mara wanders over with Adora's coffee. "Usual, Dr?"

Adora smiles up at her. "Please, and this one' s with me."

"Course, whatll ya have?" She asks Catra.

Catra's eyes snap back, wider than ever. "Uh." Her eyes dart to the menu.

Adora decides to rescue her. "Can we just get two of the same, Mar?" Barely containing her snickering, Mara walks away with a nod, taking their menus off the table. An awkward silence starts to settle in, Catra's ears flicker. "So...casual, serious...timing. Where are we at?"

"Um, maybe it' s been like...couple months? I said it was new . And I mean, whatever you're comfortable with."

"What arent you saying?"

"What?" Catra startles.

"Y ou're being weird." Adora accuses, Catra shifts uncomfortably .

"I am not being weird!"

"Catra." She turns away again and Adora grabs her hands with her own on top of the table. Catra stares at them. "Baby ," Her eyes dart up to Adora's and she blinks. Adora barely maintains her composure. "this is only gonna work between us if you're *honest* with me."

A beat passes. Then two. Then Catra cracks up and tosses Adora's hands away from her. "Y ou're an ass. Fine, whatever , if you must know; I told Merms when we broke up that Id never do casual again." She turns away , clearly a bit embarrassed. "It umit fucked with my head a little too much."

"Cool! W e're starting to get serious then. It' s new though, so that shouldnt be a big deal. Y ou said a couple months?" Catra turns back with an indistinguishable expression and nods. "Chill. Maybe we got together at your birthday party then?"

"Wait, you know when my birthday is?"

"Sure, October twenty-eighth, right?"

Catra narrows her eyes. "Are you stalking me or some shit?"

Adora laughs. "Hardly, I just have a good memory for that shit. What did you do? I feel like I remember Bow saying something about karaoke."

"Yeah"…

"Great! So, maybe I tagged along with him and Glimmer and we hit it off?"

"Why are you so good at this?" Her tone is accusatory but Adora just smiles smugly.

"Hidden talent, I guess. Thanks Mara." She smiles at her coworker as she sets down two plates of Eggs Florentine.

"Oh fuck, I love hollandaise. Lactose intolerance be damned." Catra sighs, eyeing her food as Mara walks away.

"Nice one, me too! Okay, what did you sing?"

"Huh?"

"At karaoke on your birthday?"

"Oh, Do You Wanna Touch?"

Adora raises an eyebrow and cuts into her food. "Hot. Okay, well I kill at Short Skirt/Long Jacket."

"Interesting, Ill have to see you kill it' sometime." Catra teases.

"Oh, hush you! Okay anything else?"

"Dnno dude, you've already thought about this way more than I have."

"Hmokay , oh! Are you a pet names person?"

"A w, you want a pet name?"

Adora laughs and pretends to pout. "A w, dont you think I deserve one, baby?"

"*Baby?*" Catra questions. "Do I seem like a *baby* to you?" Adora smirks at her. "W ow, okay…*Princess*. At least you didnt try kitten or some shit."

Adora snorts. "Cute. Alright, what do you do?"

"What do I *do*?"

"Y eah, that's something I should know about my girlfriend, right? Y ou know where I work."

"Oh, like work. Im a software engineer ."

"Cool, I know nothing about that and probably still wouldnt if we were really dating." Adora surmises, much to Catra' s clear amusement. "What about in your free time?"

"Oh, uhwell you know my friend group, I guess."

"Mhmm, Scorp said you, her and Entrapta areoh shit, what did she call you guys."

"No! No way , wee good friends, that' s it!"

The protest is enough to spark Adora's memory and she snaps her fingers. "Super Pal T rio!" Catra groans and slumps in her seat, shoving a big bite of food in her mouth. Adora's pretty sure she hears her tail thump against the bench seat, but isnt sure enough to

tease her for it. "So cute. Bow calls himself, Glimmer and I the Best Friend Squad if it makes you feel better."

Catra swallows and makes a face. It doesn't look like it makes her feel any better. "I'm aware."

"So, I know your friends, what do you like to do?"

"Fuck, I dunno. Hang with them, I honestly work *a lot*, I'm a big reader I have a plot in my local community garden."

"Aw, you do?" Catra nods and takes another bite. "Cute!"

"Shut up, what about you?"

"Ooh, okay well obviously I'm a waitress here. I'm in a local amateur basketball league, played in college till I dropped out-" She catches sight of Catra's questioning look and fills in the blank without being asked. "I have terrible anxiety, flunked all my classes freshman yeah and lost my scholarship. It was a whole thing then but I'm over it and working on paying down my loans."

"Oh." She looks like she has more questions but Adora shakes her head.

"Really, it's not a big deal now. I mean, it changed the course of my life," She laughs lightly, genuinely. "but college just wasn't for me. I probably could go back now that I know how to manage my mental health, but I'm happy here for now."

Catra nods slowly. "You're very open."

Adora laughs again, louder this time. "You mean I'm an over sharer."

"Fuck off, I said what I meant. Don't put words in my mouth."

"Uh huh, of course, my bad." Adora teases back. "Other than that I… dunno, I go to the gym with Bow regularly-"

Catra groans. "Oh fuck, I forgot you're his gym bro. I can't believe I'm dating a fucking jock."

Adora shrugs and flexes her arm, theatrically kissing her bicep and then winking at her lunch date. "Lucky you."

Catra literally falls over on her bench laughing. She eventually sits up, wiping away tears of mirth. "I hate you."

"Wow, okay, are you dumping me on our…" She looks at her watch. "Thirty-minute anniversary."

"What's your last name?" She asks as if it's only just occurred to her.

"You don't know my last name?"

"Literally why would I?" Catra defends.

"I mean, you have my number saved in your phone so…"

"Who puts last names in their phones? Especially if it's not a work associate."

"You know what? I'm not even gonna touch that one. It's Greyskull."

"What is?"

"My last name. We should talk about boundaries."

"Uh…"

"Wow, you really did not think about this at all, did you?" Adora pushes, relentlessly giving Catra a hard time. Clearly, she can take it. She's really fun honestly, gives Adora just as much shit as she doles out.

"I mean, I didn't think anyone would be crazy enough to say yes so… You were saying about boundaries though."

"Right! PDA, what's your vibe?"

"Eh, I'm not big on it anyway. But maybe we should like hold hands and stuff?"

Adora sharpens her gaze, she's not trying to be vague here. "And stuff?"

"Okay, listen, you're the one doing me the favor so let's start with what you're comfortable with."

Adora nods, that's fair enough. "Okay, yeah. Hand holding's cool, hands really anywhere a sports bra and shorts wouldn't cover really is fine."

Catra nods seriously. "Okay, that's actually really helpful, thanks. And uh, same. What about..." She winces. "kissing?" Adora knows her jaw drops, she really doesn't mean for it to, and Catra hastens to explain. "I mean! I'm not about to like, plant one on you. Totally unnecessary. And probably won't even come up, I guess I was just thinking like, a kiss on the cheek or something if it felt appropriate?"

"Oh." Adora laughs as the small amount of tension the unexpected question brought on leaves her. "Yeah, I'm cool with that. Anything else?"

"Uh, I guess the only other thing is just like, don't fuck with my tail, and my ears are super sensitive." She turns red again. She's cute all bashful like this, and her ears *are* pretty dang cute too. Now all Adora wants is to ruffle them. "Not that I assume you'd ah hem, just so it's out there though. Anything else on your mind?"

"Do you have a social media presence?"

Catra makes a face. "The last Instagram post I made was something like two years ago. It was my cat."

"*Aw!* You have a cat?"

Catra smiles more warmly that she has all day. "Yeah, Melog. They're a brat but I love them." She offers her phone and Adora scrolls through her camera roll. It's filled almost entirely with pictures of a sleek, blue-grey cat. They're big too, like bigger than a normal housecat. At least, Adora thinks so.

"Wow, okay, I love them too." Adora decides and it wins her a smile bright enough to blind. "We should follow each other on social media still, I'm like, semi active. And if it were me, I'd stalk my ex's new boo."

She opens Catra's Insta and follows herself. Then she sends herself a picture of Melog. "Okay, c'mere."

Catra looks wary but does as she's told. Adora waits till she settles in next to her and then takes a series of selfies. "What the hell?"

She rolls her eyes. "For me to post. It's gonna look hella weird if you're not on my feed at all."

"Right"…

"I'll post it Thursday, so it doesn't look fishy."

Catra goes back to her side to finish off her food. "You're really too good at this. Am I not your first?" Adora raises her eyebrows suggestively. "Ugh, you perv! You know what I mean."

Adora smirks roguishly, entirely unrepentant. "Whatever, no, I've never pretended to be someone's girlfriend before. I mean, other than at the club to fend off skeezy guys or whatever."

"Word."

"So what now?"

"Pick you up at six two weeks from now?" Catra answers with a smirk.

Adora frowns, not totally sure why she's doing so. "Sure, sounds good."

The rest of lunch is chill, but a weird feeling still lingers in Adora's periphery. She begs off a few minutes earlier than she needs to but tells Catra to take her time. She's inexplicably relieved when Catra shakes her head and insists that she's ready. It *is* an awkward situation she supposes.

Mara has all sorts of questions when Adora hops on the floor. She does her best to avoid her but isn't able to evade her most basic questions. Nor her teasing when her girlfriend comes to pick her up and they linger at the counter.

"I'm just saying, Dr." She wheedles as Adora makes a fresh pot of decaf.

She turns and with a hand on her hip asks, "What? What is it that you're just saying?"

Mara turns and shares a smirk with Hope, who's sipping on a cup of tea next to her. "I mean, you're going on a date with a hot girl… there's an open bar"…

Adora scoffs and resumes her task. "What? You think I have no self-control or something? I'm just doing her a favor."

"Famous last words." Hope smirks around her cup of tea. Adora flips them off and disappears to the back. Surely there's work to be done somewhere far, *far* away from these hooligans.

*

On Thursday Catra's phone chimes. It's a notification from *Instagram* of all things. Apparently, she's been tagged in a post by…. She blushes.

'***Adora-Bull*** *tagged you in a post*.

She hastens to open the app, for the first time in like, forever. Adora's posted one of the selfies she took at the diner. It's honestly pretty cute. Her smile is wide and bright and Catra's clearly rolling her eyes. She can't ignore the fond little smile quirking her lips up at the corner though, and the sight makes her blush. Thank fuck she's alone at her desk right now, no witnesses. The caption reads, '*#tbt This cutie visited me at work! I like her a waffle lot…'* It makes Catra blush harder.

She scrolls down further. There's already like, twenty comments, because of course there are. Mostly it's just people expressing surprise of Adora's new dating status. Catra's sure there'll be a lot of broken hearts around the world today. The thought makes Catra slam her phone down on her desk. She winces, praying she hasn't cracked the screen, and doubles down on her work. Of course, not a minute goes by before a buzz from her phone distracts her again.

Adora

Hey!

Was that post okay?

Feel like maybe I should have run it past you…

Catra gulps.

Catra

All good

You're a dork tho

A waffle lot? Really?

Adora

DL

I mean…

Catra

Wow can't believe I'm dating a nerd

AND a jock

Adora

I know

I'm one lucky girl…

Catra

Wow

Just wow

Adora

Nbd, nbd

Catra rolls her eyes and slaps her phone down again. This is so *weird*. Like Adora would ever look twice at her if not for this favor. Not that Catra gives a shit! Blond, buff and babely isn't really her type, not typically. Besides, she could have flirted with Adora *loads* of times before this and never did. Why would she suddenly be keen on her now?

She growls at her own thoughts, her life isn't a fucking rom com. As if to spite her, her phone buzzes again. She doesn't *want* to look, but she immediately does so.

Adora

Hey, I'm off tonight.

Catra's pulse jumps.

Adora

Bow, Glim and I were gonna go to happy hour

Wanna join us?

Immediately this seems like asking for trouble. Then again it might be good to spend more time around her supposed girlfriend before the party. It's hardly going to be convincing if Catra is all jumpy next Saturday. And, as established, she's not into Adora so there's no real risk.

Catra

Sure, Im not busy

When and where?

Adora

Great!

We're meeting at 6

Crimson Waste

Catra searches her memory and vague images of a dive bar she went to in college float to the surface. She's pretty sure she got trashed and did karaoke there a few times junior year . Then she tries to imagine Adora there it fits actually .

Catra

Sounds good

See you yahoos then.

The rest of her workday drags by and she ends up cutting out early. It's perfect because she's hardly trying to go to a dive bar in her suit. She heads home and throws on leggings and an old hoodie then decides to call a ride. No need to force herself to go back for her car in the morning. She's dropped off just in time to see Adora hopping out of a small pickup truck and waits for her by the door.

She's a total doofus. She drops her keys and fumbles for them. After she drops down out of Catra's sightline to grab them she stands and looks around for witnesses. That's when she spots Catra. She smiles sheepishly and saunters over.

"Hey! You made it." Her smile relaxes into something more genuine.

"Said I would, didn't I?" Catra challenges. Adora just smiles and digs out her wallet and ID, showing it to the door guy as they make their way in. It's nice and warm in there, Catra probably should have brought a warmer coat. She's fine now though, and after a couple drinks she'll be glad to not have to lug it around. Besides, what's all the fur good for if she has to pile on some ridiculous puffer?

Wordlessly they make their way to the bar and Adora flags someone down. She's buff as hell and tall with a light purple tint to her skin. The smile she shoots Adora, and the one Adora shoots back, makes Catra's skin crawl. "Heya Blondie!"

"Hey Huntara! Oh!" She turns to open her stance so Catra is included. "Huntara, this is my friend Catra. Catra, Huntara."

Huntara eyes her up and Catra's skin keeps crawling, the fur along her spine starting to bristle. "Hmm, friend, huh?" She winks at Adora. "This is Instagram girl, isn't it?"

Catra shouldn't be preening internally, but she is. Adora throws an arm around her shoulders and winks back. "What's it to ya, Tara?"

The woman snorts and pulls out a bottle of tequila. "Absolutely nothing, Blondie. How many tonight?" She waves the bottle.

"Oh, Catra, you doing shots?"

"Uh sure, why the hell not?"

"Cool!" Adora bounces on her heels, all goofy and giddy. And what the fuck is this girl gonna be like drunk? "I think just two to start with for me."

The two women look at Catra expectantly and she shrugs. "Can I get three please? And a beer, just whatever's on tap you'd recommend."

"Hmm, please, I like this one." She nods approvingly, setting up their shots.

Adora rolls her eyes. "Please, you act like I come in here with a bunch of heathens."

"You met your roommate?" Huntara questions, pushing their shots across the counter with a raised brow.

Adora just laughs at her and picks one up. "That's only because you intimidate the shit out of her!"

Catra snorts and grabs a shot of her own. "Damn, you manage to get Sparkles to shut up?" She and Adora cheers and knock back their first round while Huntara pours Catra's beer, laughing at the comment.

"I'm perfectly nice to Glitter." And *oh*, Catra likes this woman.

"Whatever you say, Huntara." Adora pacifies, knocking back in second shot in tandem with Catra. She makes a stupid little face and shakes her head at this one, and Catra laughs at her. She takes her third immediately after, just to get it out of the way.

Out comes her card and she slides it over to the bartender. "Mind starting a tab for me?"

"Sure thing, Blondie's on there too?"

"Yeah." Catra shrugs and Huntara nods approvingly. She drops a bottle of hard lemonade in front of Adora and turns away to ring their drinks through.

"Catra!" Adora protests, even as she follows her to a high table. "You didn't have to cover me."

Catra hops on a tool and her tail sways behind her. "Don't be a dummy, your three drink are hardly gonna break the bank. Besides, I still owe you one."

Adora pouts but at Catra's unamused stare it relaxes into a languid smile. "Well thanks." Catra nods, satisfied, then turns when Adora perks up at the sight of something over her shoulder. Bow and Sparkles have arrived. They wave and gesture to the bar and Adora gives them a dorky thumbs up.

"So, you come here often I take it?" Adora gives her a questioning look. "The bartender seems to know you pretty well."

Adora laughs prettily. "Oh, Huntara and I go way back. But yeah, I started coming here as soon as I turned twenty-one. As much to support her business as anything. It's a good vibe though."

Catra nods approvingly and looks around, Adora's right. It's a pretty standard dive bar; long bar stretching in front of Huntara, mismatched tables scattered around the room, and minimal décor on dark walls. Simple and no nonsense, it makes Catra wonder when she stopped coming to places like this and started frequenting bars like Crystal Castle, where she and Bow had been the week prior.

It's a Thursday so the bar is decently quiet, even with happy hour going. Still, Adora and Catra settle into comfortable silence, people watching their fellow patrons. Then their friends are upon them.

"Hello Catra." Glimmer says, far too formally with her eyes on Adora.

Adora rolls her eyes and Catra looks between them, answering with a simple, "Hey Sparkles."

Glimmer huffs and takes her seat. "Adora." She greets her roommate simply, eyeing her up and down. "Tara said you two did shots." Adora shrugs. "You're gonna get sloppy." She sing songs.

"It was only two!" Adora defends. "Catra did *three*."

"Woah, keep me out of whatever this is." Catra looks to Bow who just shrugs and takes a long drink from his cocktail. She doesn't even want to know what makes it *purple*.

"Yeah, this isn't about *Catra*." Glimmer sasses. "Besides, she's a Magicat, there's no comparing your tolerance to that."

Adora pouts. "Whatever. How was work?"

"Subtle non sequitur there, Adora." Glimmer rolls her eyes. "It was fine, Adora's a wreck about this upcoming case but the firm's more than prepared."

"You full time yet?" Catra asks with mild interest. "Thought you didn't graduate law school till spring."

She shakes her head. "I just help out on breaks. Mom doesn't want me to get lazy or complacent."

"Yikes."

"Tell me about it." She laughs humorlessly. "So." Catra already hates that tone. "You see Adora's Insta?"

Yep, hates it. Catra shrugs. "What about it?"

Her eyes flit to Adora whose glaring daggers back at her. "It was cute."

"I guess." Catra responds, waiting for the other shoe to drop.

"You two are cute together."

"Glimmer!" Adora admonishes, turning a little pink.

"What? You're the ones starring in your own real life rom com together. I'm just saying-"

"Enough, Glim." Adora's most likely not the only one turning pink now. Catra down the rest of her drink to cover for the heat in her cheeks.

"I'm getting another. Anyone else need anything?" She eyes Adora's nearly empty bottle and receives a grateful, pleading look in response. She nods and makes her way to the bar.

"Hey, kitty was it?" Huntara asks when she sidles up to the bar. Catra growls at the joke, but she puts her hands up. "Don't mean nothing by it, got it wrong I take it?"

"Catra." She bites out begrudgingly.

The bartender nods slowly, her expression is obnoxiously knowing. "Another round for ya, Catra?"

"Please, and another of whatever crap that was you gave Adora." Huntara laughs and gets to it.

"So, how do you and Blondie know each other anyway?" Inexplicably this makes Catra shuffle with discomfort.

"Sparkles and Archer over there. Bow and I went to school together."

"Nice one." She slides Adora's bottle over and gets to filling a pint glass for Catra.

"What about you? Adora said y'all go way back."

Huntara snorts at this, passing Catra her glass and leaning on the bar. "Oh yeah, we met when she was still underage. Tried to sneak

into the lesbian bar outside the city."

Catra laughs at Adora's expense and coos just a little. "Aw, baby gay Adora?"

"Big time, and it's like she was looking for trouble. Didn't even realize when she was being invited to a threesome; I usually mind my own business."…

"But?"

Huntara shrugs and looks over to Adora. She's bickering with Glimmer, waving her arms around, while Bow clearly attempts to play peacekeeper between the friends. "She was doe eyed and dopey, not to mention already cocky as hell. Felt too bad leaving her to the wolves so I ditched the girl I was after and took her out for pancakes."

"Wholesome." Catra smirks.

Huntara laughs loud enough to draw the attention of several other patrons. "Something like that. Anyway, couldn't shake her after that." She gives Catra a look that feels a little too much like a warning. "She's a good one, loyal."

Catra nods like she knows this, could never forget it. It makes her realize just how little she actually ever bothered to learn about Adora. She's starting to wonder if that was a mistake, Adora's fucking rad. "Yeah, yeah she is."

She must cover well enough because she receives a satisfied nod and her drinks. With that she's clearly dismissed, and she wanders back to her table. Catra resumes her seat and slides Adora's bottle over to her. "Thanks!" Her smile is lazier and her words a bit more syrupy.

"Damn, Greyskull, you already drunk?" She smirks at Adora's attempt at indignation and takes a long pull from her glass.

"Never!"

"Damn, never been drunk? Shall I get us more shots?" She feigns getting up and Glimmer cuts in before Adora can respond.

"Oh no! Nuh uh, we are not starting this. She *will* take the bait and she *will* lose."

"Hey!"

"Don't even try it, Adora." Glimmer laughs. "Or do I need to remind you of what happened spring break of senior year?"

Adora goes bright red and glares at her best friend. Catra's curiosity piques. "Oh, please do."

Adora stands quickly and turns to Catra. "Hey! Wanna get some air?"

Catra looks to Bow and Glimmer who are now cracking up. She wonders briefly who she's most likely to get this story out of. Bow and Glimmer have the biggest mouths on the planet, but Adora's had far more to drink. She figures worst case scenario she can press Bow later, so she stands from her seat. "Sure."

They walk out to the alley that runs alongside the bar. A few feet from the door Adora stops and leans against the brick, propping one foot on the wall and closing her eyes. She hums out a deep exhale then turns toward Catra and opens her eyes. They're *bright*, bright blue. "Hey."

Catra feels the tequila zipping through her extremities, her tail practically buzzes with it. "How ya doing, Princess?"

Adora giggles. "Cute. I'm good, bummer about Glimmer though."

"Oh?" She can feel a joke coming on.

"Hm, yeah. Gonna be a pain to find a new roommate. I mean, who wants to move at this time of year?"

"Ah, yeah that's true. No one wants to haul boxes in the snow."

A snort and Adora gestures around them. "What snow?"

Catra rolls her eyes. "Whatever, besides the point."

Adora sticks her tongue out. "It's *not* beside the point. I hate that it never snows here."

"It snows!"

"Blech, that slushy, watery shit. If I can't start a snowball fight or make a snowman, it doesn't count."

A little laugh like a squeak escapes Catra. "What about that storm we had two years ago?" She's mostly just being a brat, but the storm in January two years prior *was* pretty knarley.

Adora is unmoved. She throws her hands up and pushes off the wall, swaying only slightly. "Two years ago! And it was completely anomalous."

"Wow, big word drunkie."

"Psh, hardly." Catra eyes her up, she's swaying gentle like leaves in a breeze. "Shut up! I'm tipsy at worst."

"If you say so." She's really just teasing. Adora probably is more than just a little tipsy, but she's nowhere near sloppy. Her feet take her a step closer, to a distance just this side of 'more than friendly'.

Adora blinks a few times then a smirk unfurls across her face. "I say so."

"Good."

"*Great.*"

Catra laughs. "You're an idiot."

Adora just shrugs, still merry as can be. "I know ." A few beats of silence pass then Adora leans back on the wall. "So, you excited about this party next week?"

All Catra can come up with is a groan and she slumps against the wall next to Adora. Their shoulders brush but Catra totally doesn't notice. She's far too consumed with her woe, and it doesn't matter anyhow. "Absolutely not."

"Don't you have at least *some* friends at work?"

"Well, I mean, yeah of course."

"Who?" She blinks owlishly at Catra.

"Uh I mean Entrapta-"

"Entrapta Entrapt why does that sound familiar ."

"Seriously , Princess? Entrapta *Dryl*."

"Oh *shit!*" Adora hollers, clapping her hands over her mouth immediately after. Looking a little embarrassed, she lowers them just enough to uncover her mouth to whisper, "Sorry! Sorry I just she' s *amazing*. Like, an actual mad scientist."

Catra snorts at the assessment; it' s dead on. "Yeah, tell me about it. She's always been like that too."

Adora raises an eyebrow and turns. Only her shoulder and arm are pressed against the wall and she's facing Catra. She moves to mirror her. "Longtime friends?"

Catra smirks. "Oh yeah, Entrapta and I go *way back*."

Adora narrows her eyes suspiciously at Catra's tone. They fly open with dawning realization. "Fuck! Huntara told you about the threesome, didn't she?" Catra just about *dies* laughing, bending at the waist with her tail curling up behind her. "Shut up!" Catra does

not, in fact, shut up. "I'm still not sure that's what was happening, they were really nice!"

"Only fanning the flames, Adora." Catra manages to squeak out between her giggles.

Adora groans, a playful undertone to the sound. "*Oh my gosh*, Catra. Stop! Quit laughing at me!"

Catra finally manages to settle and wipes tears of laughter from the corners of her eyes. "How old were you even? Huntara didn't say."

"Seventeen." Adora grumbles below her breath.

"*Seventeen?* And they let you *into a bar*"?

That brings a little bit of Adora's confidence back and she shrugs nonchalantly. "Guess I've always been mature."

"Uh huh." Catra gives her an unimpressed look. Adora smirks harder somehow.

"Plus I've always been athletic, I wasn't a shrimpy teenager." She flexes her muscles which is rather ineffective with her puffer on.

"Wow!" Catra opens her eyes in false wonder. "And have you always been so humble too"?

Adora laughs and wraps an arm around her neck, pulling her into a headlock. And yeah, she *does* feel strong. "Oh yeah, baby. Always." She releases Catra, both of them still laughing, to say, "I'm fucking cold. Ready to go in"?

"Sure thing, Princess." Adora rolls her eyes and grabs Catra's hand to pull her inside. It's a very chill, friendly thing to do.

It's also a very chill, friendly thing when, instead of turning left toward their table, Adora pulls Catra to the right. "Photobooth!" Squealed

excitedly is the only explanation Catra gets before she's pushed towards just that.

"What? Adora, no fucking way!"

"But it's *fun*!" Adora whines with an exaggerated pout. "C'mon baby, *please*? For me?" It shouldn't be persuasive, but it is.

Catra relents. "Fine, dummy. Get in the stupid booth." Adora exclaims gleefully and hops in, Catra following after. It's a bit of a squeeze so she's half on Adora's lap. "How drunk are you anyway?"

"Psh! A little at most. Barely at all. Shut up." She just laughs at the drunk human beneath her, relaxing into her position and into her own buzz. "Okay," Adora starts once she's swiped her card. "here we go, smile!"

Catra scowls for the first one. "Like this?"

"Catra!" Adora scolds, no less amused than she was ten seconds ago. She pinches her side and Catra can't help but laugh just in time for the second shot. For the third Adora wraps an arm around her shoulder and makes a goofy face. Catra rolls her eyes dramatically and playfully.

And then... the final shot. Catra figures she owes Adora at least *one* smile offered of her own volition. She stares straight ahead and grins at the camera. Just as the flash goes off, Adora kisses her cheek. She's frozen, and the tension in the air makes it seem like Adora is too. Slowly, Catra turns to her.

She's watching Catra with wide eyes. "Was that... okay?" Catra's hand drifts up so her fingers graze the spot. "You said if it felt appropriate, but I guess... maybe that's just for the party?"

She shakes her head. "All good."

Adora brightens, accepting the approval easily. "Yeah?"

Catra clears her throat. "Y eah." Hastily she climbs out of the booth to wait for their pictures.

Adora hovers by her shoulder the whole time. Catra feels weird. Kind of shaky, tail poofed, and she's incapable of focusing fully on anything. Adora doesn't seem to notice, humming along to whatever song is playing in the bar.

"Oh! They're cute!" Adora takes the photos from the machine and hands a strip to Catra. "Look at your little scowl!"

That snaps her out of her stupor, and she laughs, shoving Adora's shoulder. "Shut up! I'm not cute."

"Y eah," Adora snorts. "Okay."

With that she marches back to the table and, shaking her head fondly, Catra follows behind. Glimmer and Bow are talking animatedly, a fresh round for all four of them on the table. Glimmer breaks off immediately to give them an amused look as they wander back.

"Y ou were gone awhile."

Missing or ignoring the implied teasing, Adora hops on her seat and shoves the photo strip in Glimmer's hand. "W e did photobooth!"

"Oh *really?*" She looks down at the pictures and Catra doesn't understand the progression of emotion over her face. Her eyes flick up to Catra, who startles and takes her seat. Then she looks back to the strip and then to Adora. "They're cute."

Her friend snorts, taking her pictures back. "W ait! Lemme see!" Bow demands, plucking from her hand and immediately cooing over them.

Adora snorts. "T ry telling Catra that." She responds to Glimmer.

"What?" She looks to Catra, clearly confused.

"She says she' s not cute."She sticks her tongue out at Catra again and accuses, "Y a dirty stinkin' liar ."

"W ow, okay."Catra takes a gulp of her drink. "Thanks for the refill by the way."She looks between Bow and Glimmer and the latter waves her off, still too busy cooing over the photo strip.

"Sowhat did you two talk about?"Glimmer ask, way too invested for Catra's taste.

"I dunno."Adora picks up her bottle, looks to Catra and shrugs. "Stuf f?"

"W ow, Princess."Catra teases. "Stuf f, really? I didnt even ask the qestion and Im unsatisfied with the answer ."

She laughs good naturedly. "It' s a talent."

"Hey Bow."Glimmer grabs her boyfriend' s attention without looking at him, her gaze staying on Adora and Catra. He turns to her and silently passes the picture back to Adora. Immediately she pours over it like its brand new to her. Catra pats her pocket to make sure she hasnt lost her copy .

"Y es dear?"

"Y ou and Catra met in college, right?"

He furrows his brow, Catra too for that matter. She definitely knows this. "Uh, yeah."

Glimmer smirks, now looking right at Catra. "What was she like anyway?"Adora looks up with interest then. "I dont think Ive ever asked."

Catra's tail flicks dangerously. It would probably be more effective if Glimmer could see it. Bow laughs and looks at her with a friendly smile. "Super scary ."

"Yeah, and don't forget it, Archer." She tells him, meeting his gaze.

He just laughs again. "Nah, you've gone soft."

"Careful, Bow." She warns. "Those are fighting words." She unsheathes her claws for good measure. Not that Bow would ever believe she'd hurt him, but the reminder can only help her case.

"Woah." She looks over to Adora who's staring at her hands. When she's caught looking, she meets Catra's eyes and with a lazy smirk she comments. "Sharp."

And Catra loses a second life, dying from laughter at the expense of Adora Greyskull.

"Well spotted."

"Ahem." Sparkles regains the attention of the group. "Scary how?"

Bow gives his girlfriend another weird look. He's so fucking oblivious, even Catra can see what she's doing. Though Adora seems pretty oblivious too, waiting for Bow's answer with that lazy grin still in place. "You know Catra, she's just." He waves at her. "Intimidating."

"Hm, so how did you become friends exactly?"

Bow relaxes a little and laughs at this, looking over to Catra fondly. "Cat's secretly a brain."

"*Bow!*" She growls at him, her tail flicking hard enough to thump against her chair leg. She sees Adora look down and smirk at it, but she doesn't comment. "Shut the fuck up."

"Well, you were! I still don't understand why you're so weird about people knowing you're smart."

"I'm very smart, thanks Bow. I'm just not a fucking nerd."

"Meh, arguable. *Anyway*," He cuts of f her attempt at a rebuttal. "I was having a *horrible* time with math and *Catra* here was in my class and worked at the tutoring center."

"*Aw*," Adora coos, her head now resting on her hand, elbow on the table. "you were study buddies?"

"He *payed* me." Catra asserts.

"At first, yeah." Bow smirks and Catra leans back to cross her arms, her right leg crossing over the left. "Then she found out both my dads' are teachers and had already put eight boys through school."

"Y ou still payed!" She insists.

He just scof fs. "Y eah, in history notes and tortilla chips."

Glimmer's head is tipped to the side and she's giving Catra a funny look. "How have I never heard this story?"

Catra glares at her friend. "Because Bow' s *supposedly* forbidden from telling it."

"Why?" Adora asks, bewildered.

"She thinks I always try to make her sound like a saint."

Catra feels herself turn red. "That' s not what I said! I literally *never* said that. You just wax on poetic about what a good friend I've always been, and then you get emotional, and I don't know what the fuck I'm supposed to do with that!"

Bow pretends to wipe away a tear and sniffs. "*Such* a good friend, the patron saint of math and tortilla chips."

Adora gasps and sits up in her chair. "W ait, that's who that candle was for? Or-Or you are I guess."

Catra groans at the reminder and Bow beams. Honestly, it's fucking hilarious and she's been burning the candle slowly since last holiday season. To make it last. Bow had decoupaged one of those stupid pillar candles to look like the ones people burn at like, church or on alters or whatever. "Yeah, that's me, Princess."

Adora laughs uproariously, actually slapping her knee. "Amazing! Honestly? Some of your best work, Bow. Glad it went to a worthy recipient."

"Okay, we're officially done talking about this. Thanks a lot, by the way." She glares at Sparkles who smiles smugly. "What time is it anyway?"

She digs out her phone and is disappointed to see that she *should* actually head out. She has a meeting in the morning and never actually ate dinner. Bar food is *definitely* not gonna cut it at this point.

"Aw, you gotta go?" Adora asks when she sees Catra's face.

"Yeah, gotta be a responsible grown up sometimes."

"Boo! It's my Saturday, we gotta stay out and get *wild*!"

Bow and Glimmer laugh at her and the latter teases, "Please, you'll be asleep within the hour."

"Nuh uh!"

Glimmer raises an eyebrow. "Bet me."

Lips pursed, Adora works her jaw for a minute then spits out, "No." There's another round of laughter and Adora stands up by Catra. "I'll walk over with you while you close your tab."

Catra smirks and allows it. As they walk away, she teases, "Babe, you getting clingy on me?"

Adora groans. "Ugh, no I can just already tell Glimmer 's got some bug up her butt." She offers Catra a conspiratorial smile. "Just delaying my fate."

Catra scoffs and waves to Huntara when she catches her eye. She cashes out and waves as she and Adora walk to the door. "Thanks for inviting me out."

"Thanks for coming! This was chill, we should all do a game night some time."

Catra's ear flicks and her head tips ever so slightly to the left. "Sure." Adora just smiles back and Catra shakes off whatever odd feeling was creeping up her neck. "Well, have a good rest of your weekend."

"Thanks, bye Catra!" She leans in to peck Catra's cheek for the second time that evening then spins and walks away. Catra wanders out the door and calls a ride.

It's not until she gets home that she realizes that her fingers have lingered on her cheek for the entire ride.

"Good morning, *Princess*!" Adora's roommate trills, just moments after she snoozed her alarm. Her first snooze too, there is no justice.

"Glimmer ." She groans, burying her face in her pillow to block the light from her now open curtains. "Hell spawn, get out of my room."

"Nope! We have to talk, and then I'll make you breakfast."

Adora hesitates at the mention of food, she can already tell this hangover is going to demand carbs very, very soon. "What are you making?"

"There's waffle batter ready in the kitchen." She can hear Glimmer 's smug grin in her voice.

Adora whines. "Can we just talk *over* breakfast?"

"No way!" Glimmer laughs. "That's my only insurance I'll get a single answer out of you."

Adora grumbles but unburies her face and turns onto her side. Glimmer has already made herself comfortable, leaning back against the headboard with her knees pulled to her chest. Adora sits too, staying snug under her covers. "What's up?"

"Catra." Adora groans once more and covers her face at the answer. She huffs and takes a deep breath then lowers her blanket.

"What about her?"

"Listen," And *uh oh*, that's serious face. "I know I was teasing you about your life being a romcom"…

"Yes?"…

"You two have real chemistry!" She rushes out.

Adora rolls her eyes. "Glimmer, *please* dont make this weird."

"I'm *not*. Look, just-have you looked at the photo strip this morning?"

"I mean no, but I get it, it was cute. How many times have you and I, or Bow and I, or you, Bow and I, taken cute pictures though?"

Glimmer shakes her head, expression still steady and serious. "Where is it, Adora?"

"My pocket, I guess?" Glimmer gets up and digs it out. She hands it to her with an expectant look. Dutifully, Adora studies the photos.

Like she said, it's cute. In the first Catra has a cute little scowl while Adora smiles brightly. In the second, Adora remembers goosing her. She's laughing brightly while Adora looks on with a wicked grin. Adora's being a goof in the third and Catra's arms are crossed, her

face playfully exasperated. The fourth, of course, is the kiss Adora'd given on her cheek. Catra is smiling demurely. She looks back to Glimmer.

"Well?" She asks pointedly. Adora looks at it again and shrugs, waiting for the explanation. "I'm sorry, did you *look* at the fourth one? I mean they're all a little cute for just friends, *but*…"

Adora rolls her eyes at Glimmer's reach. "Please, I've kissed *your* cheek. Are you saying that was romantic?"

Glimmer shrugs. "I mean, I did have a crush on you when we first met-"

"Wait, *what?*"

"but I get what you're saying. *I'm* just saying, look at her face. Hell, look at *your* face. I can't remember the last time I saw you look so… jubilant."

Adora snorts. "Okay, wow, so much to unpack here. Uh, I guess first," She smirks. "you had a crush on me?"

Glimmer just gives her an impatient look. "Please Adora, you've seen you. You also have the personality of an overgrown puppy. *Of course* I had a crush on you. If I wasn't already with Bow, I probably would have asked you out."

"Aw, Glimmy!" She smiles conspiratorially with her and stage whispers, "I probably would have said yes."

Her best friend scoffs and Adora allows herself to be pushed over. She rights herself immediately. "Thank fuck it didn't work out. No way there's enough room for both of our egos in a romantic partnership."

"Ha! Word. Alright, seconded. did you just use the word *jubilant*?"

"I literally cannot think of a better way to describe you last night." She explains simply.

"Uh, how about *drunk*?

"Mm, no. I'm gonna stick with jubilant." A beat passes and Glimmer raises an eyebrow at her. "You gonna ask about the third thing, or do I not need to spell it out for you?"

"Spell what out for me?"

"Guess that answers that." She responds primly .

"Where's Bow anyway?"

"Gone already , he had to swing home before work. Stop trying to distract me."

"He should really just move in already , he's here all the fucking time." Adora points out, genuinely sidetracked now.

"Conversation for another time, we can talk over breakfast. Focus."

"I'm just *saying* it would save us all on rent, plus Bow has all the best board games, *and* he and I carpool to the gym all the time anyways."

"Oh, I get it. It's not that you think it would be good for me and my boyfriend to take this next step in our relationship. You just want to move your best bro in." Glimmer laughs at her .

"Uh, yeah." Adora tells her in a tone that screams, 'duh'. "That's literally my whole thing. Also, the rent thing. Seriously Glimmy, I wanna pay like thirty-five percent less rent. It sounds good, it sounds *real* good."

Glimmer laughs harder and nods, agreeing, "Fine, yeah, okay . Bow and I have been talking about it too. We can talk next time we're all home. Now, back to the topic at hand!"

"Sorry , what was it?" It' s a genuine question, Glimmer 's still plenty unamused.

"Adora! Look at Catra and tell me those aren't heart eyes."

Adora looks down and immediately back up. "Those aren't heart eyes." She deadpans.

"Adora!"

"Seriously , Glimmer, you have got to chill. I'm not over here pining for Catra, okay? I'm like, just now getting to know her ."

That gets a scoff. "Please, what is dating if not getting to know someone? Besides, you met years ago."

"You know what I mean, Glim."

"Fine, whatever . I stand by what I said about the heart eyes."

Adora groans, starting to get impatient. "Okay , and what if she is? If I am? We're two single, consenting adults, would it be the worst thing in the world if we decided to date?"

"You have got to watch more romcoms." Glimmer mutters. And then, "That' s not my concern. Honestly, after last night I can actually totally see you two making sense."

"Oh." Adora frowns, confused. "I don't get it then, what' s the concern?"

"You're both stubborn as hell. If you're both insisting that there' s no romance, there will *be* no romance. Which whatever, live your life or whatever. I just think this whole going on a date and casual touches and *cutesy pet names* thing might get confusing."

"So what are you saying, Glimmer?"

She takes a deep breath. "I think you should ask her out for real. You should tell her you've realized you're interested. If she's not also interested, I think you should politely decline to attend this party."

Adora stares at her, hard. There's no waver in her eyes. Adora breaks the stare. "I think I've earned my waffles now."

Glimmer deflates but doesn't argue. "I suppose you have. Let's go eat, ya useless lesbian."

*

Monday turns out to be the longest day of Catra's life to date. Her meetings drag on and go over time. Her computer decides to throw a temper tantrum. She has to eat at her desk to make up for lost time. And, *and,* Mermista fucking Sealineas chooses *today* of all days to rear her head.

"Hey Bluth, what's up?" Catra growls, flicking her tail and thrusting her mouse away. "Ooh, that bad huh?"

Catra rolls her eyes. "Not at all, Mermmy. Just a case of the Mondays."

Her ex scoffs. "Whatever. Saw that pic your girl posted."

That makes her smirk. "*Wow*, Merms. Checking up on me?"

"As if. Sea Hawk knows her."

Catra's stomach bottoms out, she's not even sure why. "*How?*"

"Pft, I don't know. He knows so many fucking people. I do *not* understand extroverts."

"Weird."

"Anyway, the pic was cute, I guess."

"Gee, thanks for your approval, babe." Catra turns back to her work. The gesture isn't so much dismissive as it is necessary. She is seriously pushing it for time today.

"Whatever. I should get back."

Her left ear flicks absently. "Bye Mermmy."

"Bye Kitty Cat."

Catra growls at her ex's retreating frame, claws digging in to the wood of her desk. The moment she's gone Catra pulls out her phone.

Catra

You know Sea Hawk?

The response is almost instant. It still feels to Catra like an eternity.

Adora

Oh, Sebastian?

I love that guy!

Catra barely maintains a loud moan of despair. Why do people like that guy? He's so fucking obnoxious!

Catra

For real?

Adora

?

Catra

Guess who he's dating

Adora

Uh I've seen her on Insta…

Idk her name though

Catra rubs at her forehead, trying to come up with the best way to explain. It's not like it matters, right? Adora's doesn't even know his girlfriend's name, sounds like their hardly super tight. Why is she even getting worked up about this? Sea Hawk's probably too dumb to put the situation together, even if he had all the pieces. Which he doesn't. So, she's fine. Adora's texted back while she worked through her little breakdown.

Adora

OMGOODNESS

That's YOUR Mermista?

Catra

Princess

How many Mermista's do you know?

Adora

Okay, fair point

Is this like…

A problem?

Catra

Uhhidk

I dont think so?

Mostly just weird

Do you think it's a problem?

Adora

No!

No, I barely know him.

We were in the same improv group.

It was ages ago tho.

Catra decides it's time for a little break. A short walk outside should reset her brain nicely. She calls Adora the second she's out the door. "I'm sorry, you do *improv*? I feel like that's something you should have mentioned at the diner."

Adora's warm laughter trickles across the line. "I *did* improv. It was after I dropped out. My therapist recommended it as a way to build confidence."

"Psh, like you need more of that."

"What's that supposed to mean?" she laughs.

"*Please*, Princess, you're cocky as hell."

"Alright, Ill give it to you on a technicality. Still, just means the improv classes worked, doesnt it?"

"Holy fuck, Im dating an idiot."

"Lucky you. Listen, Im actually about to clock in but would you wanna come over Wednesday?"

Catra's heart skips, which is really fucking weird. Since when does she have social anxiety? "What's on Wednesday?"

"Game night! I'm working the breakfast shift the next day, so we won't go super late. But Bow just got the *big* bananagrams so. We gotta play."

"Bananagrams you say? Yeah, I think I can fit that into my schedule."

"Uh oh."

"What?"

"Sounds like The Brain is about to come in and give me a run for my money."

"Aw," Catra mocks. "afraid of a little competition?"

"Wow, okay, Duth. I actually really have to go, but I can't wait to beat your pants off on Wednesday."

"Good luck."

"Hm, thanks, but I don't need it." Catra just laughs and hangs up on her.

The rest of the day flies by, she even manages to get ahead on some emails. She'll have to remember how much good a little fresh air can do.

"You mash that avocado any harder I think you're gonna leave a bruise." Adora stares at Bow, glances down into her bowl, and looks up again.

"I'm making guac."

Bow laughs and sits at the kitchen table. "I know you are, Adora. You're just being very thorough."

"Oh." She looks at her bowl again. It *does* look pretty good. She shrugs and starts chopping her veggies.

"You feeling wound up at all?"

"Uh, no?" He gives her a look. "I went to the gym after work! I'm chilling."

"So, you *did* feel a little wound up?"

"What? No, I'm just saying even if I *had* any excess energy, I would have burned it off at the gym."

"Okay." His tone tells Adora all she needs to know about his actual opinion. "I'm excited Catra's coming. She's usually more of a one-on-one hang kind of gal."

"Really?" Adora asks curiously. "Any reason?"

"Nothing specific. Just more her vibe, I guess. She'll show up to events and stuff, I mean you've seen her, but I think she's just really introverted. Usually we just do happy hour every other week or so."

"Funny, well she's chill. I can't believe it took us so long to have like, an actual conversation."

"Right…"

"What, Bow?" She turns to face him one arm holding her bowl on her hip, the other stirring her veggies in.

"Nothing."

"Please, you're terrible at hiding shit. Out with it."

"I just think it's cute y'all are hitting it off."

"Glimmer get to you?" He makes a noncommittal face that obviously means yes. "Whatever . Im ignoring her about it and if you start in on me, Im ignoring you too."

"Fair enough." He raises his hands in submission. "I'm just here to play games."

"Excellent, same. Now , try this." He doesnt hesitate to do as he' s told and gives Adora a big thumbs up as he dives in for more. She laughs and leaves him to it, heading to her room to put something other than boxers and a bro tank on.

Catra arrives sometime while she's in her room. Bow has her and Glimmer flipping over tiles, the three of them already set up with drinks. "Hey Adora."

"Catra! Hey ." She smiles, crossing the room and reaching into the fridge for her own bottle. Glimmer clears her throat pointedly. Adora attempts to ignore her with decent success.

"Ready to get your ass beat at Bananagrams?"

"Please." Adora scof fs, taking the seat beside her. "Get ready to lose, Catra."

She helps finish getting tiles flipped then draws her starting letters. Glimmer gets them going with a quick, "Split!" And they're of f, making their individual crosswords. So much better than Scrabble, Adora loathes waiting her turn. People take so dang long at Scrabble.

Glimmer is a slowpoke as ever, no real competition. She's cute though, sticking her tongue out a little as she concentrates. Bow is more of a scowler, scratching his head and humming to himself. He reminds Adora of his dads, which is hilarious. Catra is clearly the most competitive, besides Adora of course. She uses her arm to shield her words and moves at lightning speed. She also calls "Peel!" more than anyone else. Which is infuriating, frankly.

When they're down to two tiles, not enough for another draw , Adora's leg is jiggling under the table. Out of nowhere something soft brushes across her ankle and up to her knee. Catra's tail. She suppresses a shiver and doubles down on her focus. She only has one letter left! Still, Catra is shouting, "Bananas!" before she can find a place for it.

Catra leans in to whisper in hear ear, "I told ya." Adora suppresses another shiver and looks over at her words.

"Catra." She smirks.

"Yes, Adora?"

"Are all of your words gay?"

Catra smirks back. "It's not impressive if there's no theme, Princess."

"I agree." Adora nods to her own crossword. All three of her friends look at her board, then Catra's. They actually have a few of the same words; 'queer', 'sexy' and 'cunnilingus' all appear on both. Overall, they're both working within a general gay , saucy theme. Catra starts cracking up, Bow looks flummoxed and Glimmer makes direct eye contact with Adora, smirking smugly.

"Damn, Princess. You got some good ones. Sixty and nine crossed? Nice." She holds up a hand for a high five and Adora obliges. It's enough to break Bow out of his trance and he starts laughing along.

"You two are ridiculous." Glimmer comments passively .

"Aw, Sparkles, jealous because you finished with, what? Like fifty tiles?"

"Shut up, Catra!"

"Nah, dont think I will."

"Havent you ever heard it's unbecoming to gloat?" She sasses.

"Havent you ever heard I dont give a flying-"

"Alright! I want ice cream." Bow stands from his chair and ends up getting something for everyone.

They retire to the couches to chill for a bit, before Adora needs to kick everyone out so she can go to bed. It's nice, comfortable. It's sort of funny in a way; Adora' s had infinite evenings spent like this with Bow and Glimmer. Yet it feels totally natural to have Catra here with them, she fits seamlessly into their banter and flow.

There's a prickling sensation at the back of her neck when they bid Catra adieu later in the evening. Adora wonders if The Best Friend Squad is destined to become a foursome.

Catra doesnt have very much work to do on Friday . She could probably dip out early but decides to hassle Entrapta instead. That woman works far too much. She's sat on her desk while her boss fiddles with something. It might be a fucking robot for all Catra knows, or cares for that matter.

"So." Entrapta starts after a prolonged silence. "I heard you're bringing a person to the party tomorrow."

From anyone else it would sound leading, not Trap though. She's not even invested enough in Catra's response to turn away from her project. "Uh yeah."

"Is it a person I know? Mermista said she' s your girlfriend. I didnt know you have a girlfriend."

That's interesting. "Mermista was talking to you about me?"

Entrapta pauses, tilts her head to the side and looks at Catra. "Oh, is this weird because you dated Mermista? Are your feelings hurt?"

She seems to second guess this. She turns on her recorder and asks it as much as she asks Catra, "Are Mermista' s feelings hurt?"

"T rap! No! No one' s feeling are hurt. Im just gonna give her shit for it later."

"Oh." Entrapta considers this for a moment then gets back to work, pulling her goggles over her eyes once more. They settle into silence again and Catra starts playing with the Newton's Cradle on the desk next to her . "So, do I know her?"

"Uh," Catra tracks the movement of the balls with her eyes and feels her tail sway predatorily behind her. "I dont think so. Her name is Adora? She' s friends with Bow and Glimmer."

"*Ohh.*" Catra' s gaze is drawn back to her friend, but her left ear cocks back to continue to track the sound of the desk toy. "Y es, I met her at a social gathering once. She seems very nice."

"Y eah, she's chill."

"How long have you been dating?"

Catra hesitates; to tell the truth or to not tell the truth? She doesnt think her friend will judge her , but it *is* just the sort of thing she would let slip mindlessly. "Like five, six weeks? W e got to talking at my birthday, she showed up with Glimmer after you left."

"Y ou didnt mention it."

"Huh?"

Entrapta looks up but her goggles stay on. She always looks a little eerie like this to Catra. The fur along her spine ruffles. "Y ou never said you went on a date."

"Ohuh, well we only recently made it of ficial." It' s not like this is hugely out of character for Catra, she's not exactly an open book.

More like one of those diaries with the tiny padlocks, the key for which doesn't even work half the time.

"I see. So, it's serious."

"Sure." She shrugs, forcing nonchalance. Her heart is thudding, and she doesn't understand it. It's not like Entrapta of all people is going to catch on to this harmless lie.

"You said after Mermista you don't want to date casually anymore." She states it like it's just a simple fact. It *is*, Catra supposes. There's just some nuance.

She grits her teeth. "I did say that, yes."

"Does Adora want kids?"

"*Excuse me?*"

"Well, you've always wanted kids, right? It would be smart to find out if she wants them or not now, so you don't waste time if there's inevitably-"

"Entrapta!" That gets her attention, she turns to Catra and pulls her goggles up this time. "Look it's just new still we're still figuring things out and we haven't talked about that yet. I would *appreciate* if you didn't bring fucking kids up to Adora."

"Oh, okay . What if she brings them up to me?"

Catra blinks, this conversation has spun wildly out of her control. "I uh I think you're safe, bud."

She shrugs and takes this at face value, turning back to her work. Silence settles in once more, the balls still clacking loudly. It's not comfortable this time though, and Catra's lost her interest in the toy. She just can't stop thinking about *kids* and Adora, and kids *with* Adora. It makes her stomach ache and flip, and she should *not* be thinking about this. It's weird, right?

She stands abruptly. "Well, I have a fuck ton of work to get done, so I'm gonna go."

"Bye Catra." Her friend calls without looking up.

Catra fusses a second longer then nods and walks out of the room. As she closes the door she calls back, "See you tomorrow, Trap." She looks to Entrapta's assistant as she walks out. "Someone's gonna like, call and remind her about the party, right?"

Hordak smirks. "Of course, Ms. Duth. Do you think that I am an amateur?"

Catra snorts and shakes her head, walking to her desk without another word. That guy is fucking obnoxious and arrogant as hell, but there's no denying he's better than anyone ever has been at keeping up with Entrapta. He may be her 'assistant' but everyone at Dyl know Hordack is her right-hand man.

Catra drags out her work about as long as she can before calling it a day. She still leaves a half hour early. After work she thinks about driving home, but she feels jittery. Maybe she should stop somewhere for a drink, just to take the edge off before she heads home to make dinner. Maybe she'll even see if Scorpia wants to join her. The two of them haven't caught up in a while.

Without really thinking about it she ends up parked outside Crimson Waste. She's a little surprised at herself but figures it's better that Crystal Castle on a Friday night. She gets out and heads inside. The person at the bar is new to her, some goat hybrid who she thinks introduces herself as Kyle or something. She gets her beer with minimal small talk and Catra settles in at the end of the bar.

Catra

Hey Scorp

What's up?

She gets a response almost immediately, typical Scorpia.

Scorpia

Wildcat!

Hi!

Nothing much!

I get off work soon :):):)

Catra

Wanna grab a drink?

I got off early, Im at Crimson W aste

Scorpia

Say no more!

I will be there soon!

Wait for me!

Catra rolls her eyes and doesnt bother to assure he shell be there. She literally invited her out. She sits there a few minutes longer, watching the after work crowd start to trickle in. She's soon bored of this and turns her attention to a TVsituated over the bar . It's tuned into some sports game and Catra watches without really taking anything in.

"Hey pretty lady , can I buy you a drink?"A voice nexto her ear startles her out of her daydreaming.

She rolls her eyes, ready to tell this asshole off;she did *not* come here to be bothered by some barfly. "*Listen*, cretan, Im not sure-Adora?

The blonde is smirking at her, laughter dancing in her eyes. "Now , is that anyway to talk to your girlfriend, baby?"

Catra's pulse jumps, she' s surprised. "What the fuck are you doing here?"

Adora takes the seat next to her and raises an eyebrow . "If you recall, this is my regular haunt. What are *you* doing here?"

"Stalking you."

Adora laughs. "A w, baby, all you had to do was call me."

"Y oure an idiot."

"Y eah, yeah."She waves her of f. "Are you here alone?"

"For now , Scorpia's gonna head this way after work."

Adora's eyes light up. "A w!How' s she doing? I havent seen her in ages."

"Pft, no one has. Ever since she and Perfuma got together it' s been hard to pin her down. I think she's happy though."

"Ah, young love!"She smiles through a dreamy sigh.

Catra scoffs in amusement. "Y eah, something like that. So, are you here to drink alone or?"..

Another laugh, warm and easy. "Not tonight. Im actually helping out, Huntara had a last second call out."

Catra's eyebrows fly. "Y ou work here too?"

"Nah, not really . I did for like, a year though. Hours are a bit much for me, but I still help out from time to time. I get paid under the table and the extra cash is nice."Catra nods slowly . "Anyway , I should hop on."

"Right, yeah."

"Lemme know if you need anything." And with a wink she circles the bar, washes her hands and gets to work.

Suddenly Catra's very interested in people watching again. Or, at least, in Adora watching. She's just magnetic. She fields the crowd effortlessly, laughing openly and loud enough that the sound filters over to Catra over the din of the bar. She's clearly very good at this. Then suddenly, she's serving Scorpia. Catra pulls out her phone and pretends like she *wasn't* just watching her friend do her job for the better part of a half hour.

"Wildcat!"

She looks up from her phone. "Hey Scorp."

"Did you see *Adora* is working here? Is that why you picked this place? You know, she is *so* nice." She hops onto a barstool, her tail just narrowly missing smacking Catra in the face. "I mean, I guess *you* of all people would know that."

She winks obnoxiously and Catra cringes, glancing over to Adora to make sure she isn't listening. She's not, too busy serving some dumb looking lizard hybrid chick and making her laugh. Not that Catra cares. "Whatever."

"You excited for your holiday party tomorrow?"

She narrows her eyes and her tail flicks. "Scorpia, who in their right mind gets excited for an *office holiday party*?"

Unfazed, her best friend just shrugs. "Adora said she's excited."

Catra blanches but covers it quickly. "Yeah, well she doesn't work with those idiots." Scorpia gives her a look and she groans. "*Obviously* I'm not talking about Entrapta."

She laughs amiably. "Well, anyway." She darts her eyes, *very obviously,* over to Adora and leans in. "How have things been with… *the ex*?

"Why are you whispering?" Catra whispers back.

"I just didn't know if your *date* would appreciate-"

"Not actually my date, Scorp."

"Why is that?"

"*What?*"

"I'm just saying, you're available, she's available. You're nice, she's nice. Why not just ask her out for real?"

Catra splutters at the question. "I-well and she-you just don't-Scorpia! She's pretending to be my *girlfriend*. Besides, how shitty of a first date would it be to take her to the *Dryl holiday party*?"

"Hm, so where would you take her?"

"What? I don't-"

"Hey guys!"

Catra squeaks and jumps about a foot in the air, her tail doubling in size. Adora, who appeared out of nowhere on the other side of the counter, howls with laughter at this. "Fuck, Princess! Wear a fucking bell or something."

She just smirks back. "What are you talking about over here?"

Catra flexes her jaw and wills her face not to heat. Unfortunately, this gives the woman seated next to her right plenty of time to swoop in. "Say Adora, what would be your idea of a perfect first date?"

"Ooh! Good question what season is it?"

Catra laughs. "What dif ference does that make?"

She rolls her eyes like Catra's missing the point on purpose. "Uh, I need to know if outdoor venues are on the table."

Scorpia considers this. "Hmokay , give us both;one sayth is time of year and one with no weather constrictions."

"Okay , okay." She looks like she' s thinking *way* to hard about this. "Okay , this time of year;getting warm drink and walking through Brightmoon Park to look at the lights. Then after, we'd go to that little ice cream shop on the west end of the park and share a banana split!"

"Y um!"

"*Ice cream?*" Catra challenges. "It' s fucking freezing out!"

Adora smirks at her. "Dnt tell me the magicat is a bigger wimp about the cold than I am?" She just scof fs at the smug challenge in Adora's voice.

"And the other option?" Scorpia prompts.

"Hmprobably a day hike, go see a waterfall or some shit. Then grab lunch after for sure. I get like, *super* hungry hiking."

"Y o Adora!" She turns to look at her coworker . "I gotta run to the restroom, mind manning the bar a second?"

"Sure thing!" She turns back to her friends. "Either of you need another round?"

Scorpia gestures with her half full bottle and Catra shakes her head. "Nah, Im driving."

"Cool, well say goodbye before you head out. And you're still picking me up at sixthirty tomorrow , yeah?"

"Sounds good, Princess." Catra confirms. The second Adora walks away she rounds on Scorpia. "The hell was that?"

Her attempt at looking innocent wouldn't fool a baby. "What? Just making conversation with my friend."

"I literally hate you."

"Aw!" Scorpia wraps a claw around her shoulders. "You could never hate me!"

Catra rolls her eyes but yeah, that's true. In that moment though, Catra hates herself just a little bit for mentally filing Adora's answers away. Just in case.

"*Damn*, Glimmy!" Adora praises, wolf whistling in her roommate's bedroom doorway. "You sure clean up good."

She catches her eye in her vanity mirror while she finishes applying some sparkly goop to her lips. Smirking, she asks, "Me? What about you?"

Adora knows how cocky her grin must be, sticking one hand in her pants pocket and gesturing down her body with the other. "What, this old thing?"

"Hm," Glimmer hums, standing and spinning around with just enough movement in her hips to make the skirt of her sparkly purple dress fan out. "trying to impress someone?"

Adora rolls her eyes but…*okay*, maybe after last night she realized she does, *maybe*, possibly have a *tiny* crush on Catra. But like, she's a grown ass woman and will not be brought down by some little, harmless *crush.* "Shut up Glimmer, this is literally the only suit I own."

She tuts, clearly unconvinced. "That shirt looks new."

Adora looks down like she forgot she went out and bought a dark green button down for the occasion. It was a good call;it looks *very* good with her blue suit. Even if she does say so herself. "Whatever . When is Bow coming by?"

Glimmer glances as the delicate silver watch around her wrist. "Should be here any second actually . Catra's coming at half past?"

"Uh huh."

"Cool, well Im ready . I know this thing is gonna have an open bar, but I was thinking a shot for the road?"

"Oh, hell yes!"Adora' s maybe, just a little bit, jttery . She leads the way into the kitchen to pour them each a shot, which they down immediately and unceremoniously. Then, there's a knock at the door and her heart kicks into overdrive.

When Glimmer opens the door both Catra and Bow are waiting on the landing. They're laughing about something but trail of f at her appearance. "Hey babe!Hey… *Catra*."

The latter gives her a weird look and slips past Bow who's leaned in to give her a kiss on the cheek. "Hey Sparkles."She looks around the room and her eyes finally land on Adora.

Adora kind of wishes it had taken a little longer to be spotted. Her heart went from racing to a full stop in a second. Catra lookswow , just wow . She's in a dark maroon suit with a black button up below it. The cut is *very* flattering. She's also put on eyeliner that makes her heterochromatic eyes *pop*, and her hair has been like, tussled or teased or *something* that has made it fluffier and curlier than ever.

"Hey Adora."

"Catra!"She sees Glimmer snickering out of the corner of her eye and dies a little inside. "Ahem, hi. Y ou look nice, really nice."

Her date saunters over and tugs on the lapels of her jacket. "You don't look too shabby yourself there, Princess."

"*Okay*," Bow cuts the rising tension from his spot by the door. "Catra and I were just saying maybe we should carpool in my car. Since the three of us are all coming back here, and her car is here. So... shall we?"

"Sounds good!" His girlfriend trills, pausing to kiss his cheek once more. "Let me just grab my jacket. Adora? Come with me?"

She gives her a weird look. "To grab your jacket? Do you need help with that or something?" Catra cackles beside her and it makes Adora feel a little warm and fuzzy inside. Or maybe that's the shot. Who can say?

Glimmer grits her teeth and gives her a challenging look. "Well, you need to grab yours too, don't you?"

"Uhh... yeah. You do realize my room is on the opposite side of the apartment though?..."

Glimmer groans theatrically and throws her hands up. "Adora! Girl talk! In my room. *Now!*"

"Oh. *Ooh!*" Adora hums with understanding. "Am I gonna listen to you gush over Bow's suit now?"

And then, as if to prove just what a total bitch she's capable of being, her best friend cocks an eyebrow and challenges, "Am I gonna listen to you gush over Catra's?"

Adora *knows* she must be turning red now, at least if Bow's smirk is anything to go by. She huffs a breath out through her nose and glares daggers at her *former* best friend. "I hate you. Fine, let's go get your stupid jacket." She follows her into her room and closes the door behind her with a loud snap. "What the fuck, Glimmer! Why are you so determined to make this night weird?"

She just scoffs. "Adora, you were drooling."

Instinctively, infuriatingly, she touches the corner of her mouth with her fingertips even as she protests. "I was not! Shut up!"

"Adora." She whines, doing nothing to endear her to her plight. "Will you *please* just admit you're into her? It's getting like, painful to watch."

"Glimmer." She warns.

"You two are like, weirdly perfect for each other! I mean the banter and the *pet* names."

"Okay, one the names are a joke and part of this favor that I'm doing her. Two, butt the fuck out."

"But-" Adora whirls around and opens the door, marching past Bow and Catra in the living room to go get her jacket. They're looking between her and Glimmer, amusement dancing in their eyes.

"Are we ready?" She asks once her jacket is on. Her voice is stern and she's looking only at Glimmer, which earns her an eyeroll. Still, there's a general consensus and they make their way down to the car.

The party is being held at some swanky hotel downtown. The lobby and the ballroom have been decorated decadently; lights, candles and garlands everywhere. The whole place smells strongly of pine. Adora *loves* this season, and she's *very* into it.

Glimmer gets stopped almost immediately by some associate of her parents and Bow stays behind with her to schmooze them. Catra and Adora slip away quickly and make their way to the coat check. Of course, the distance from Glimmer offers Adora no peace on the whole 'are you into Catra' issue.

As soon as they're alone, waiting in line, Catra starts in. "So girl talk."

Adora turns away and pretends to survey the room. "Y ep."

"What was that all about?"

She's eyeing an elaborate chandelier in the center of the room but can *hear* Catra's smirk. "Glimmer being a pain in my ass." She grumbles, finally turning to face her smug date.

"A ww, poor baby."

She laughs. "Shut up!"

"Hm, don't think I will."

"W ell, you should."

"Oh yeah? And why is that, Princess?"

"I'll pout." She states simply .

Catra blinks then bursts out laughing. "Y ou'll *pout*?" Adora juts out her bottom lip in answer. "Hm, hate to break it to you but that's not all that persuasive."

Adora bats her lashes. "Just wait till we're an hour in."

It's their turn to step up and shed their coats. Adora drops her pouting and thanks the attendant kindly. Immediately after Catra leads her over to the bar. She orders a dry martini with a twist for herself, which is such a classy drink. Adora's not even sure what's *in* a martini. Vermouth? That's a thing, right? She keeps it simple and just requests champagne.

A voice behind them startles her while they wait for their drinks, and she doesn't miss the way Catra groans under her breath. Adora feels

the smallest flick of her tail behind them. "Why if it isn't two of the loveliest ladies at this entire event!"

Adora turns around and can't help but smile. And like, she gets Catra's attitude, Sebastian Hawk is a lot. But she fucking loves this guy. "Hawk!"

He's sidled up to the bar with the infamous Mermista and suddenly Adora is nervous. She takes Catra's hand. "Adora, it has been far too long! I don't believe you have met my lovely Mermista."

Adora stick out her free hand, faking confidence she doesn't feel. "No, not yet! Nice to meet you."

Mermista raises her eyebrow and doesn't take her hand. Which, rude. Adora looks to Catra from the corner of her eye but she's taking their drinks from the bartender. At least accepting her glass gives her something to do with her hand. "So you're Catra's new girlfriend."

And *oh*, it's gonna be like that. Catra opens her mouth to say something but Adora doesn't give her the chance. "Yup. And you're Catra's *ex*-girlfriend I take it. My condolences to you."

She thinks she sees a hint of a smirk at the corner of Mermista's lips, but it's gone just as fast as she spots it. If it was ever there at all. "Hm, I was about to say the same."

And now Adora's pissed. Catra on the other hand just snorts. "Fuck off, Mermmy."

She narrows her eyes and Sea Hawk cuts in. "Ahem, so, Adora, how have you been?"

Adora wills her blood to simmer down from its boiling point. "Uh, yeah, good. I left Huntara's place and I'm over at Razz's Diner these days."

"Ah, the beautiful Huntara! Do you still keep up with her? I think maybe she got a new number; she never answers my texts…"

Unwilling to touch *that* with a ten-foot pole, Adora takes the question at face value. "Yeah, she's doing good. Crimson Waste is doing better than ever."

"Wait a second." Mermista interrupts. Adora wants to like, kick her shin or something. Seriously, Catra *dated* this asshole? And for a long time too. "This is the *owner* of the Crimson Waste? I went there like, *all the time* in college."

Catra's smile turns smug. "Oh yeah, she and Adora go *way* back." She smirks at Adora and her stomach flutters with nerves. "Isn't that right, Princess?"

She smirks and bumps her shoulder into Catra's. "I regret ever letting you two speak unsupervised."

"Hey, you made your bed."

"Right." Mermista drawls. She's eyeing them boredly, Sea Hawk is watching their exchange too but is far more rapt. "Anyway, I should go find someone else."

Catra scoffs. "Miss you, Mermmy."

"Lovely as always, Catra. And Adora, we should catch up sometime. I can take you out on my boat! The Dragon's Daughter Three."

Adora laughs. "Sure, just text me or something."

"I surely will." With that he and his rude girlfriend take their leave. Adora sticks her tongue out at Mermista's back. When she turns around Catra is watching her in amusement.

"Well, guess I don't have to ask what you think about my ex?"

She can't help but roll her eyes. "Seriously? What did you ever see in her?"

Catra laughs and starts leading Adora away from the bar. "Don't mind Mermista, she's just dry. Takes some getting used to."

"You say dry, I say fucking rude." Catra pauses to turn and look at her face. Almost absently she squeezes her hand. "What? I don't mean to like, dump on your ex but *come on*."

Her date shrugs and resumes her progress. "She was just being protective."

"Protective?" Adora asks, not bothering to hide the doubt that colors her voice.

Another, slightly infuriating shrug. "Mermista is fiercely loyal. She was just feeling you out." Adora bites her tongue, choosing not to share her opinions on that take. "She *was* rude to you though, so I'm sorry for that. I'll say something next time I see her."

They stop in front of one of the tables spread out around the dance floor. Catra sets down her drink and Adora follows suit. "Don't bother. Listen, I'm gonna run to the bathroom. Are you gonna be here or will you be mingling?"

"I think dinner's starting soonish, so I'll just stick here. You saw it on the way in?" Adora nods and heads in that direction, immediately pulling out her phone to text Glimmer and Bow.

She reaches the all gender restroom and figures she might as well pee while she's there, so she slips into a stall. It gives her a moment to take a deep breath, plenty of time to wonder what she's so worked up about. So Catra's ex is a bitch as it turns out, so what? After tonight it doesn't affect her any. Will it continue to affect Catra though? She didn't exactly *seem* bothered, and she said they're on good terms. But still…

She's just finishing up when Bow's voice calls out. "Adora? You in here?"

"Yeah, just a sec!" She finishes up and walks out. Bow is leaned against the counter waiting for her and she walks over to start washing her hands.

"Hey, Glimmer's with her parents talking to some important bigwig. She'll probably be stuck there a while."

"It's chill. Um, sorry I called you in here. I think I'm just being silly."

"Well, I'm here now. What's going on?"

She huffs. "I met Mermista." She dries her hands with much more force than is necessary.

"Oh." Is all Bow says, clearly waiting for more.

"Was she always so..." She gestures vaguely in the air in front of her. "Even while they were dating?"

"I mean, Mermista's pretty dry, yeah."

Adora rolls her eyes, that's what Catra said too. "Look, I'm fine with dry, I get dry. She was fucking rude."

"Oh." He frowns, his eyebrows knitting together.

"Yeah! Like, scoffed when I tried to shake her hand, was basically sulking like she was there against her will, and, *and* basically the first thing she said to me was insulting Catra!"

"Okay, yeah, that's a little weird"…

"Do you think..." Adora bites her lip, turning to face the mirror and fussing with her hair. She should have just pulled it up like normal. "Do you think she's still into Catra?"

"*What*?" Bow laughs with genuine surprise. "No, not at all. Their relationship was weird anyway. They were kind of always more like exclusive friends with benefits."

Adora turns and crosses her arms over her chest. "How is that different than dating?"

"It just wasn't ever very romantic. They were attracted to each other and they care about each other a lot, but I don't think either of them expected it to last as long as it did. Let alone forever or something like that." Her narrows his eyes at her. "Did Catra tell you why they broke up?"

Adora thinks back on their conversations. "I mean she said she doesn't wanna date casually anymore. Not really though, no."

Bow smiles sadly. "It honestly might not have occurred to her that you don't know. Everyone kind of did for a while."

"Okay, are you gonna tell me?"

"It's a pretty short story. Mermista met Sea Hawk." "Ah, so that's why it fucked with Catra's head." "She denied she was into him beyond just physical attraction, but I think Catra always knew the truth. Or suspected at least. I guess they talked about opening things up but ultimately... Anyway, Merms and Sea Hawk got together a few months later and made it official six months after that."

"Right. And has Catra dated anyone since?"

Bow considers her for a moment, tipping his head ever so slightly. "A little. No one who ended up being serious in the end."

Adora nods, considering this. There's a prickling at the corners of her eyes that doesn't make sense to her. "Bow?"

"What's up, friend?"

"I think I might be a cliché. Or-or a trope or whatever."

"Adora?" He cranes his neck a bit to catch her eye. "Why does it feel like you think that's a bad thing?"

"I-I guess I feel like I'm doing something wrong." He's clearly perplexed by this. "This is literally exactly what she said she *didn't* want to happen! She wanted to bring *Glimmer!*"

"Okay, yeah, but is it cheesy if I say that's before she met you?"

She rolls her eyes and looks down at her shoes. "Yeah, Bow, it is."

"Look, I just really don't think this is gonna be a problem. I *do* think you should say something though. I'd be really, *really* surprised if she wasn't receptive."

"Yeah, maybe." She looks up. "Catra said dinner was supposed to start soon, and I've been gone awhile. We should head back."

"Okay if you're ready."

"Yeah," She tells him, steeling her voice. "I'm ready."

⁂

This night is turning out to be surprisingly fun, Catra thinks. Sure, Mermista'd been a pain in her ass but nothing new there. And it *was* kind of funny to see Adora and Sea Hawk interact. She's still not a fan but something about their combined energies made something click in her mind. She turns in her seat, wondering not for the first time where her date wandered off to.

Honestly, it's Adora she has to thank for this night turning out as good as it has. She might have been an idiot for putting herself in this situation, but she lucked into a really awesome date. Her mind catches on the word. *Date*. She can't help but think that she never wants to have to attend another event like this without Adora by her side. She can't help but think how much fun they'd probably have

doing something else. Something likewalking through the park looking at holiday lights.

She's interrupted from her musing when someone drops into the seat nekto her . She turns with a smile but instantly deflates when she registers the person nekto her . "Oh, hey Sparkles. Where' s your boy toy?"

She shrugs. "Bathroom."

"Y eah."She frowns. "Adora too but she' s been gone *awhile*."

"Oh, Bow' s with her."

Glimmer has her attention again. "W ait, what?"

"Uh huh, she wanted help with something or to talk maybe."Glimmer waves her hands dismissively. "I dunno, I was stuck listening to some old dude drone on about *something*. So, Bow went alone. I was gonna join them, but I saw you by yourself and honestly , I just really wanted to *sit*. Heels are such beautiful torture."

"Is something wrong?"Glimmer frowns at the question and looks in Catra's eyes. The longer she looks, the more her eyes soften, and her little smug smile grows.

"W orried about your date, Duth?"

Catra growls lowly. "What' s it to you?"

"Y ou like her, right?"

"What is this, eighth grade?"

She rolls her eyes. "I'll take that as a yes."

"How about you take that as mind your own damn business?"

"Y ou should go for it."

Catra groans and empties her glass. She looks around for a waiter, no luck. "Great, thanks for the unsolicited advice. You're not at this table, right? I think dinner is starting soon."

She just laughs like, *isn't Catra being* so *funny?* "Fine, fine, I'll shut up. Just think about it. I think you guys would be cute together."

"Glimmer?" Catra turns. *Thank fuck*.

"Oh, hi Adora." Glimmer greets her.

As glad as she is to have her date back, the sight of Adora makes Catra feel funny. Too warm and the fur on the back of her neck raises. Plus, she suddenly can't keep her tail still to save her life. She catches it under her thigh. "I was just keeping Catra here company till you got back."

Catra scoffs. "If that's what you wanna call it."

"Alright, going back to my own table now. You know, somewhere I'm *appreciated.*"

"Bye Glim." Catra laughs at Adora's even tone. She walks off with her usual Glittery flair and Adora reclaims her seat. "Hey!"

Catra smiles back at her. "Hey, everything good?"

"Yeah!" Adora answers brightly. …*Too* brightly? "I ran into, Bow and we got caught up."

Okay, yeah, definitely a little too bright to be genuine. "Cool. He having a good time?"

"Oh yeah, think he was glad to have escaped whatever boring conversation Glimmer got stuck in."

Catra narrows her eyes, her tail fights to free itself. "Right." Before she can think of where to take this conversation, it's announced that

dinner is beginning. Out of nowhere servers appear with their meals. Catra is able to order another drink, which is something of a relief.

Adora groans at her first bite and Catra can't help but smile. Adora smiles back sweetly. "You know, I don't really *get* fancy food, but it definitely hits different."

Catra laughs. "In what way?"

"You are what you eat, right? And this is what? The third life Catra loses dying from laughter, all because of Adora Greyskull?

Eventually Catra's coworkers around the table pull them into conversation. Mostly they ask Adora basic getting to know you questions. Catra's glad Adora had the foresight to establish a backstory for them, cause that comes up. It's a fine group, but Catra's not interested in socializing with them longer than necessary to be honest. The minute speeches end and dancing starts up she's pulling Adora from her chair.

"You promised me a dance, Princess."

Adora smirks and raises an eyebrow. "Oh, did I?"

"Yep. Don't tell me you filled your dance card and forgot all about me."

Adora grins playfully and the nearest of their tablemates titters. "Aw, baby, I could never forget about you. You get as many slots on my dance card as you want."

She's teasing, flirting maybe, but still just teasing. Either way Catra's heart does a few clumsy somersaults. "Alright, show me how it's done, Greyskull."

Adora laughs and follows her to the floor. They come together naturally, Catra taking the leading position and Adora following. The song is fast and fun, their steps playful and teasing. Catra's not sure

what she expected but she's surprised at how good a dancer Adora is. At the end of the song, she chances dropping her into a low dip.

Adora looks up at her, smiling and laughing elatedly. There's pink high in her cheeks and in that moment, time stops. Just for one moment. Catra barely notices when Adora's leg slides between hers. Nor when her own tail moves to wrap around her calf.

And then the moment ends.

They move to stand properly, smiling widely and catching their breath. And suddenly someone is beside them.

"Catra!"

She jumps about a foot in the air , her tail going ramrod straight. "Entrapta! Fuck, don't sneak up on me like that."

"Sorry! The experiment is going well, isn't it?"

She sees Adora looking at her questioningly and she mouths the words, *I'll explain later.* "Yeah, Trap it's great. I'd like you to meet Adora. Adora, this is Entrapta."

Her eyes go comically wide. "Oh! Entrapta, nice to meet you."

Entrapta waves and Adora offers a wave back, her lips quirking to the side. "You're Catra's girlfriend."

"I am!" She catches Catra's eye and hers are alight.

"That's nice. Are you enjoying the party?"

"Yeah, it's been great. Thanks for having me."

"Yes, Hordak did a very good job with the planning."

"Her assistant." Catra answers Adora's unasked question.

"Gotcha."

"Anyway , I just wanted to say hi. I'm gonna go see if I can find the tiny cupcakes we ordered."

Catra laughs. "Get me and Adora one too if you track them down."

"I will see what I can do."And just as suddenly as she arrived, she' s gone, disappearing into the crowd of dancers.

Catra and Adora dance together for a little while longer. Soon enough Glimmer and Bow find them, and they do a quick dosido. Glimmer taps Catra out and sends her off to her boyfriend. At some point her parents wonder over too and Catra catches sight of Micah trying to teach Adora some new, fancy step. She's cute, watching her feet and biting her lip in concentration.

When the music switches to something slow the couples resume their original pairings. Catra feels her heart heavy in her chest, its normal rhythm pounding against her rib cage. They sway for a moment and Catra hears Adora yawn. She sees Glimmer slumping on Bow a couple feet away.

"Ready to head home after this, Princess?"

Adora sniffs, when she shifts to look at Catra's face her smile is soft and lazy . "Whenever you are."

"Are you even gonna be awake much longer?"She teases.

Adora hums and leans her head on Catra's shoulder. Now her heart finds a new rhythm. "No."Adora' s voice is soft, quiet enough only Catra can hear her. "But I'm having a good time. Here, with you."

Catra clears her throat, suddenly concerned her voice wont come out like it's supposed to. "Y eah, me too."

Adora doesnt say anything else. She does, however , turn her head to press a soft kiss to Catra's cheek. And Catra wishes the song

would go on forever.

Adora and Catra hover by her car back at her and Glimmer's apartment building. "This was fun." It feels almost like the end of a date.

"Yeah, thanks again for helping me with this weird fucking favor." If it *was* a date, Adora would step closer. Lean in to see if Catra would mirror her.

"Of course, what are friends for?" She would ask permission to do what she *really*, really wants to do right now.

"Right, friends. We should hang out again soon. Maybe get a drink or something?" If this were a date, Adora would kiss her.

"Yeah! I'd love that." But this isn't a date, and it was never supposed to be one.

"Great. Then I'll call you." Her keys come out of her pocket and Adora nods.

"Great." She leans in to press a kiss to her cheek. Can she do that after tonight? Are they just… *done* being fake girlfriends? What is Catra gonna tell Mermista? Her coworkers? Adora never thought to ask. "Get home safe, Catra."

"Ahem, yeah. Thanks, Adora." She waves Catra off and watches until her taillights disappear around a corner. She goes inside, and directly to bed.

Catra doesn't call.

Not the next day, or the day after, or *at all* the following week.

"Just *text her*, Adora." Mara's voice snaps her out of her reverie. She stands up properly, having been hunched over the counter, staring at her phone.

"I don't have anything to say." A beat and then, "Don't give me that look, Mara!"

"Adora, you are pining. You're worried about being a cliché but here you are, participating in a cornerstone of the trope."

"What's *that* supposed to mean?"

Mara sighs, ever so put upon. "You have really got to watch a romcom sometime. Listen, here's the thing. In the movie, when the love interest and the protagonist go to whatever event they're pretending for, that's never when they seal the deal. First, someone realizes they're in love-"

"Woah, woah, woah! Who said anything about *in love*?"

"It's Hollywood, Adora." She explains as if Adora is being daft. "Obviously it's love. Anyway, they realize they're in love but *assume* it's unrequited. Thus, the pining."

"Uh huh, and then what happens?"

"Well, someone decides to be brave, or they figure out whatever misunderstanding took place. Then, of course, you get the grand gesture."

"Grand gesture?"

"Oh, Adora. You know, Lloyd Dobler with the boom box, the epic new year's speech from When Harry Met Sally…*and* you look like you're not getting a word of this."

"Is When Harry Met Sally the one where Meg Ryan fakes an orgasm in that restaurant?"

Mara rolls her eyes. "Yeah, Adora, it is."

"Huh, I never saw it."

"Worth it for Meg Ryan's outfits alone."

Adora purses her lips thoughtfully and nods. "Hm, noted."

"Listen, we're losing sight of the point here."

"Which is?"

"You're pining, Adora, and it's bringing the vibe down. So, could you like, text your girl and move the plot forward?"

"Shut up, Mara." She goes back to staring at her phone, and Mara lets her right up until the lunch rush picks up. Adora's mentally, emotionally and physically exhausted by the end of her shift. She checks her phone, no new messages.

It's fine, she thinks, she wasn't looking to date right now anyhow. And clearly, neither was Catra.

*

Catra calls.

Admittedly it had taken her two weeks. She just didn't know what to say, how much to put on the line. Finally, after missing Adora way more than she ought to miss a new friend, she decided. All of it, she's putting it all on the line. Mostly that just comprises of her dignity, but if she's honest there's a little bit of her heart mixed in for good measure.

"Catra! Hey!"

"Hey Princess."

"How are you? How was your holiday?"

"Good, yeah. Just same old, the holiday was good. I went with Scorpia and her girlfriend to her moms' place. How about you?"

"Great, yeah! Uh, we went to Glimmer's folk's place. Micah always makes a super elaborate meal. Anyways what's up?"

"Would you want to go on a walk later?"

A few beats pass then Adora clarifies, "A walk?"

"Uh huh, with me. Maybe around five?"

"A walk with you around five."

"Yeah, I can meet you at your place, we can go from there."

"Oh"…

"Uh Adora? Did I break you?"

"No!" She suddenly sounds much more present again. "Sorry, no. Just got distracted. That sounds great though."

"Great, I'll see you then." Adora agrees once more and they say goodbye.

That leaves Catra four hours to pace around her apartment. It's torturous. Plus, Melog keeps trying to play with her tail which is frankly a pain in the ass. She gets herself ready as early as she can justify it and packs up a bag. At half four the sun dips below the horizon and she hops in her car to drive over to Adora's place.

She answers the door, and she looks resplendent. She's all bundled up with a thick scarf, warm coat and a beanie that makes her look really, really gay. "Hey Catra!"

"Hey Princess, you look cute." Maybe it's just the cold, but Catra's pretty sure she makes Adora blush. "Ready to go?"

"Yep!" Adora locks up the door behind her and they start making their way. "Where are we going?"

"Going?"

"Yeah, I mean, it seems like we're headed in a specific direction."

Catra smirks. "There's just something I want to show you." They walk quietly for a few minutes. She's not sure what's going on in Adora's mind but personally, Catra's getting a little nervous. A block away she pauses and pulls two thermoses out of her bag.

She hands one to Adora who accepts it, her face crinkling in confusion. "What?"...

"You have a choice to make." She pauses for effect. "You can have plain cocoa or" She reaches into her bag and pulls out little airplane bottles of peppermint schnapps. "Peppermint cocoa!"

Adora grins widely. "You're amazing. Peppermint please!" They stand on the corner and doctor their drinks. One their trash is tucked back in Catra's bag she takes Adora's hand and gets them walking again. "Hey Catra? Can I-"

Adora's words die on her lips as Snowflake Lane comes into sight. It's some neighborhood near Adora's place. All the houses coordinate their lights displays and most are timed to music playing from speakers at several of the houses. It's honestly pretty impressive.

"What do you think?"

She looks at her with wide eyes. "I love it! I had no idea this was even here."

"Yeah, I drove past randomly last year. I mean, it's not the park but"...

Adora freezes, then her face breaks into the widest smile Catra's seen on her yet. "My perfect first date"…

"Yeah is that okay?"

"If this is a date?" Catra nods, her heart caught in her throat. "Yeah, I'd really, *really* like that, Catra."

"Yeah?" It's scarcely more than a breath.

"I think you're pretty amazing."

She takes both of Adora's hands in hers and steps closer. "Funny, I could say the same thing about you."

"Listen, I've been thinking about you for the last two weeks and this is *really* romantic. So, if it's cool, I'd very much like to kiss you now." It's so earnest and her eyes are on fire, Catra melts.

"Yeah, it's cool." They come together and Catra never wants to pull away. Her hands grip Adora's shoulders, Adora puts one on her hip and her other slides into her hair. After a minute they pull apart. "Hi."

"Hi." Adora blinks and looks up, then she laughs all light and carefree. "It's snowing!"

Catra looks up with her and damn it all if she isn't right. There was nothing about it in the forecast, but sure enough fat fluffy flakes are swirling down around them. "Well would you look at that. Don't you love the snow?" She looks down and Adora is smiling at her, a few snowflakes caught in her lashes.

Adora kisses her again. Her fingers comb through Catra's hair and come up to scratch behind her ears. She can't help but gasp into her mouth. Adora pulls away and she could kill her for it. She just whines a little instead. "Sorry! Sorry, I know you said they're sensitive."

Catra shakes her head. "Sensitive isn't necessarily a bad thing, dummy. Now get back here."

"Oh." Adora's expression grows cocky. "Got it."

"*Adora…*"

"Right, of course." She leans in but stops a breath away. "One more for warmth and then wanna look at the lights?"

"Yeah, whatever you want. As long as I get a kiss goodnight too."

Adora couldn't look more smug if she tried. "Oh, I think I can promise you that and then some."

Catra snorts. "Alright, Princess. Your window of opportunity is closing, so…"

"Yes, of course. How silly of me." She finally closes the last of the distance between them. This time she doesn't pull away until the both of them are overdue for a little oxygen. She pulls Catra down the street, stopping in front of every single house. She comments on her favorite parts and tells Catra stories about holidays past, pressing for stories from Catra too.

Catra doesn't mind, she's happy to stretch this date out as long as Adora will let her. And, as it turns out, that is *quite* a long time.

*

Adora's roommate bangs on her door. "Hurry up in there! We should have left five minutes ago."

She pulls her face away from Catra's begrudgingly. Her girlfriend speaks before she has the chance. "Fuck off, Sparkles! I told you, we'll call our own ride when we're good and ready." Adora laughs and starts peppering her neck with kisses.

"Absolutely not! If we leave you unattended there's *no way* you'll make it to this party by midnight."

Adora hears a purr begin to rumble through the chest below her lips. Catra's hand grips Adora's hair. "I can think of worse things, Glitter ." She sing songs.

Glimmer bangs again, Bow's voice can be heard murmuring next to her and then, "Are they adults though, Bow? *Are they?* Because they're acting like horny teenagers."Another soft murmur .

Adora pulls away, much to Catra's clear displeasure. "Glimmer , if I promise you that'well leave the house before."She looks at her clock, it's a little past eight. "Nine-thirty , will you please *go away*"?

A long pause and then. "Y ou *promise*"?

Catra snickers from her position underneath Adora on the bed. "Y es, Glimmer."Adora growls. "But if you continue to annoy me, we might not come at all."Catra gives a big thumbs up to this idea and Adora snickers, giving her a salacious wink.

A sniff. "Fine. Bow and I are leaving. W ell see the both of you *very soon*."

"Y up!Buh-bye now ."She waits until their footsteps have retreated the smiles wickedly down at Catra. "Now , where were we"?

"Hm,"Catra smirks, a cute little hint of fang at the edge of her lip. She pulls Adora's face back to her neck. "I think we were right abouthere."

Adora smiles into her neck, running a path along it with her teeth. Catra's breath shudders out, low and incredibly sexy . "Hey Catra"…

"*Hmm*...ah ha, yes, Princess"?

"Can I take this bra of f"?

"Ill be fucking livid if you dont, frankly .

Adora chuckles and takes care of the obstacle. "Catra"?

“*What*, Adora?”

She leans in close to whisper in her ear. “Happy New Y ear’s”

Catra groans and laughs, all at once pushing her away and pulling her closer. “Happy New Y ear’s, dummy. Now hurry the fuck up and get to it, before your roommate comes back here and kills the vibe for good.”Adora smirks and does as she’ s told without argument, more than happy to oblige.

They finally make it out the door two hours later, rumpled, satisfied and ready to party.

End Notes

Just some niiiice self indulgent fluff.
Taking a break from a far angstier story (If you're following The Drama of College more to come there soon!) because I can never stay away from the soft stuff for long.

Thanks for reading and happy holigays!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!